mess is mine

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mess is mine

by godblessgamora

Summary

He bites the inside of his cheek, almost like he's debating something. "Gamora…"

She steps around him without another word.

"I begged to work with you." His voice is urgent. Practically desperate.

And it's that, together with the actual words, that strucks her to her core. A shiver of something dances up her spine. She slowly turns around. "What?"

He pinches the bridge of his nose, looking embarrassed and defeated. He mutters under his nose, "This is not how… Dammit."

Notes

i wasn't going to post this today but then i saw the new starmora bts and my heart jumped out of my chest, so here i am with a multi-chapter fic. happy international v3 day to everyone who celebrates <3

this was supposed to be a christmas oneshot but it ended up being a 35k words mc story. i was too lazy to post it in december when i wrote it so we're collectively going ignore how wrong the last chapter (christmas chapter) is going to feel in june

gamora's betrayed thanos and is now working for nova prime. peter is also some sort of a contractor for the nova corps. they're aware of each others existence

chapter 1

When you think of love, do you think of pain?
You can tell me what you see
I will choose what I believe

It's Peter Quill. It's Peter Quill. It's Peter Quill.

She can't stop replaying the words in her mind.

The closer she flies to Xandar, the bigger the planet grows through the windshield of her ship, the more she can't focus on anything but those words.

It's Peter Quill.

Her gut drops a little. She tries to remain calm, tries to deal with the whirlwind of emotions in her chest, but her breath stops in her lungs. The pressure builds up, choking her, and she feels light-headed.

It's Peter Quill.

Apprehension pools in her belly. Confusion, too. So do jealousy and curiosity but it's the fear that wins.

The edges of her vision get blurry. The colours become bleak. A sudden wave of nausea makes her suck in a sharp breath, but that only causes pain. A lump in her throat feels like a rock, pushing from the inside.

She winces.

And then tries again.

Inhale. Exhale. She repeats the process over and over—until the panic fades away. Until she doesn't grip the armrest anymore. Until she can feel her own body, not lost in the rush of blood in her ears anymore.

It's Peter Quill.

Gods, what was she thinking?

Her legs shake a little when she stands up. She slowly moves down the stairs, desperate for water. It never really helps—but every single time, she hopes it will.

Hopes.

Hope. What a foolish concept. It's nothing but a mirage—one that kills more than a real, visible threat—but she can't help it. The truth of how pathetic she is makes her want to scoff, but she only gulps down a glass of water. Then another.

Then she drops her head and closes her eyes.

The blood she drew for Thanos has gotten inside her lungs. It's inside her heart, it's running inside her veins, and she's a matter of guilt, shame, and self-hatred. The sins she committed aren't redeemable, the blood will never be washed from her hands, and she's everything that's wrong—but she desperately wants to feel right.

Her chest feels tight.

She's terrified of never atoning for her past—while convinced it's impossible.

It's Peter Quill.

She shudders. In fear. In disgust. In hope.

Hope. Hope. Hope. She hates hope—because she hates herself—but she can't give up on it. If she does, then Thanos will win—and she can't give him that. He's already taken everything. But not this.

The idea of never being more than what he made her be repulses her. Makes her sick. Every time. Even now, there's a wave of nausea that rolls over her. Her throat goes dry, her stomach twisting and clenching, and when she reaches for another glass of water, her hand shakes.

Nova Prime's words ring loud in her mind.

You know I will always go on any mission you send me, but I don't do partners or teams, Irani. I work better alone.

It's Peter Quill.

Three simple words, but she suddenly had nothing to say. Words failed her—but hope didn't.

It flared up. It pulsed acutely in her chest, and she didn't realize what she did until she agreed to the job.

What a fool. Sentimental, clueless idiot.

She scoffs, frustrated with herself, and pushes away from the counter. Nervously pacing around the tiny kitchen, she thinks of storming up the stairs and turning the ship away. She wants to forget about all the responsibilities. About the mission. About the fact that she's trying to *help* and *can't* just skip on a job.

She *almost* does that.

But when her legs carry her to the stairs and she grips the handrail for support, she realizes she can't lift up her leg no matter how much she tries. Her body seems frozen, and she doesn't know if it's guilt or hope that keeps her tethered.

His world gut turned upside down too many times—and yet, he doesn't seem tainted or

cursed. He doesn't seem like he's drowning, or like he hates himself. She tried to look for the darkness she sees every damn day in the mirror, but she couldn't see even a sliver of it. No shadows. No regrets. Only *light*.

Blinding, spanless light that's always filled her with longing. Even now, a deep, strong wave of it washes over her heart, and she involuntarily tightens her hold on the handrail.

How did he find the light after everything he went through? She knows *hell*, she knows pain, and he *went* through it all. She could't learn everything when she did her research, but the bits and pieces of what she learned were enough.

Loss of his mother. Abduction. New, unfamiliar world. *Ego*.

He lost so much—but he's not suffocating.

Can she ever learn not to drown?

Hope squeezes all air out of her. So does the fear.

He thrives in the light. She's withering in it. The difference between them couldn't be more obvious. She knows she's flying towards someone who'll only shatter the broken pieces of her heart even more.

She doesn't want him to highlight everything that's wrong with her. She knows he will.

Her curiosity about him isn't worth it. Her *hope* to have the same isn't worth it. Nothing is—and yet, everything *is* worth it. Because if it's not, then Thanos is right.

She'd rather die.

She swallows thickly. This time, when she tries to walk up the stairs, her body listens.

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When she steps inside the Nova Corps headquarters, she forces herself to steady her breath. It's too late to run away now. She's already here.

The usual security protocols take little time. As always, a Corpsman on duty doesn't really look her directly in the eyes. There's no outward hostility toward her—but there's also very little warmth.

They might be unafraid of her, but they don't go out of her way to get to know her either. She reminds herself that this should be fine with her. What's the point of engaging in conversations when she's barely here in person, after all? And yet, something silly always knots in her stomach.

"Gamora."

She immediately turns around, her gaze falling on Dey. The corners of his lips lift up a little, and he gives her a nod. “Flight was okay?”

He’s the only other person, except for Nova Prime, who ever looks her directly in the eyes and seems to be happy to see her.

She feels a tweak of warmth in her stomach. The feeling has always been mutual. Something about him has always put her at ease.

She steps to the side, closer to him, and nods. “It was. What do you know about the mission?”

He starts walking and takes the first hallway to the left. She hides a sigh of relief, realizing they’re going to the Nova Prime’s office. She’s already on the edge. Being in one of the open-space strategy rooms would have been suffocating.

She can never escape anyone’s eyes there.

Dey gives her a brief glance. “One of our scientists needs to collect soil and plant samples, and she needs protection.”

Gamora frowns a little. “Why is it a two person job?”

She accompanied scientists in the past. Even under Thanos, she learned that some plants are carnivorous *and* large, and it’s impossible to be surrounded by them without protection. But she’s good. *Really* good. No one’s ever been hurt on her watch—at least, not since she started working for Nova Prime.

Why do they need Peter Quill?

Dey wrinkles his nose a little. “They need samples from Gilea.”

“*Ah*.” She nods.

It’s an inactively active war zone. There’s no officially proclaimed wars, but the resources are so valuable that many opposing forces try to stake claim. Gold. Unique DNA species used for cloning purposes. Metals used for deadly weapons.

A paradise for thieves and criminals.

“Have there been recent attacks?”

No one likes to run into somebody else. No one’s happy to let each other go in different directions.

Dey shakes his head. “Not recently. All the activity has slowed down significantly, but we want to be careful.”

He presses his palm to the reader, and she leans against the wall. “Is the mission going to take long?”

He looks unsure. “Couple weeks maybe? It’s up to Calea.” Gamora gives him a confused glance, and he clarifies. “She’s one of the two scientists and the lead of the project.”

The elevator doors open up, and they both step inside. She spends the entire ride biting the inside of her cheek and tapping her foot on the floor. When they get to the right floor, she knows she’s running out of time.

Slowly exhaling, she asks, “Is Quill aware of this being a team mission?”

Is he aware that he’s going to be working with me?

She hopes she sounds nonchalant. She’s paranoid Dey will get suspicious. She’s never asked about anyone else before, after all. She never wanted to, not until now.

They step out of the elevator, and Dey doesn’t seem to read too much in her curiosity. “Yeah. I’m pretty sure he—“

“Dey.”

She recognizes the voice even without turning around. Her heart jumps to her throat.

Dey looks over his shoulder. “Quill!” He sounds delighted.

People always have this reaction to Quill.

She holds her breath as she turns around.

The sight of him, so close to her, leaves her slightly light-headed.

She *has* seen him—but never like this. Never face to face.

She remembers faltering the first time she saw him. She feels like faltering again, so she locks her knees. She doesn’t know what else to do, completely taken aback, and simply stares at him. Soaks him up, noticing all the details she’s never noticed before.

Seeing him less than two feet away is jarring.

That time, the first time she saw him in person, right as she was leaving the Nova Corps, he was surrounded by a group of people who all looked at him like he was the sun. They were smiling. Laughing. They eyes followed his every move, and his own laughter was deep, rich.

His scars made him irresistible. Her scars made her repulsive. When people barely looked at her, they couldn’t look away from him.

She was mesmerized that day. Jealous, too. Those feelings joined the feeling of respect and awe she’d already had for him, and haven’t left her since.

She doesn't know what to do with those feelings now. They bubble in her chest, and her head spins.

The interest in his eyes—eyes trained on *her*—makes her want to run away. He takes a step closer, and hit with his scent, she stops breathing.

His lips stretch in a wide smile. "Hey! I'm Peter Quill."

She blinks at him.

A smile. He's giving her a *smile*.

No one *ever* smiles at her. In the past, there was fear. After she betrayed Thanos, there were suspicion and hatred, together with a huge dose of distrust and contempt. Now, she's lucky if she sees wariness.

But a smile?

Never.

The realization that she's not used seeing something so carefree, so *normal* directed at her hits hard. Beneath everything else, grief spreads. It's so overwhelming that she wants to turn around, hop on the ship and never face another person *ever* again. Not if such a simple interaction leaves her cracked open and hurting.

Pain sits in her chest, and she's unable to breath. It takes her a few tries before she can swallow the sad bitterness. Her voice is almost too hoarse. "I'm Gamora."

Sometimes, regular people don't recognize her face, but as soon as they learn her name, their faces lengthen. Quill's smile doesn't disappear, however. It only grows bigger, happier. "I know." He offers his hand. "It's nice to finally meet you. I've heard many great things."

The question almost leaves her lips, but she stops herself the last second. It plays in her mind, though, over and over. *How many bad things have you heard?* She doesn't think she ever wants to know the answer to this question—not just from him, from anyone. It's one thing to try and forget all the bad things she'd done and fail. It's another thing to be reminded that everyone else remembers her sins too.

She wraps her fingers around his hand, swallowing past a lump in her throat. "Likewise."

His skin is warm. His touch is strong. His eyes, the same eyes that don't leave hers for a second, leave a mark on her too. His gaze is deeply piercing. Almost like a physical touch in itself.

Goosebumps rise on her skin, and she barely hides her mortification. She *feels* the goosebumps, but can he *see* them? An embarrassment rises up, painful in her chest, and for a second, the world goes dark. There's too many emotions, too many feelings and—

This is why she doesn't do team work. *This* is why she doesn't interact with other people. She doesn't know how to.

She was taught to kill. She wasn't taught to socialize.

But *him*? He was natural the first time she saw him from afar. He was natural the second time, too.

He's natural now.

Everyone is.

The truth burns.

Her flesh does too, right where he's still touching her, so she takes a step back and pulls her arm away from him. She doesn't feel his fingers around hers anymore—but she *still* does. She feels his eyes on her face too. They're reading. Learning. Figuring out.

There's nothing good that he can learn.

Her mouth tastes sour. She turns away.

She wants to run away, but she refuses to let Thanos win.

"Come on," she says, without looking at Quill or Dey. "Nova Prime is waiting for us."

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Protect the two scientists.

Come back alive.

Leave later today, as soon as the ship is stocked up with food and other resources. Shouldn't take too long—it's going to be just the four of them. She can't decide if she should be petrified or happy about the fact.

Maybe, just maybe, she will be too focused on the mission to drown in her feelings. But she can't remember being with three other people in an enclosed space at once.

Her skin itches in the anticipation of fear. The feeling intensifies every time she briefly glances in Quill's direction. He's sprawled out in the chair, looking almost lazy and bored.

He's the epitome of calmness. She's the opposite of it.

When the meeting is wrapped up and everyone slowly leaves the room, he turns to her. "I'm going to get food for the ship because I don't trust them to give us all the fun stuff. Do you want me to get anything for you?"

She blinks at him. "What?"

He looks a little bit confused by her confusion. "I personally don't want to eat ration bars and cured meats for the next few weeks. So I thought I'd go to the market and grab the good stuff?"

This doesn't help. She frowns more. "The good stuff?"

"Yeah, like candy." He face practically lights up. He sits straighter, and she can almost feel his excitement. "Or fruit. Or, you know, chocolate. I also want to stock up on drinks. And foom pies." He looks at her expectantly. She doesn't say anything. He prompts her again. "So… what would you like?"

She doesn't have anything to say.

She's never been asked a question like that. Her preferences haven't been important to anyone. Including her.

She doesn't know half of the things she listed. She doesn't know what she likes.

Once, freedom used to seem like an opportunity to do things she hadn't done before. Now, it only highlights all the ways she's failing to feel—and be—normal.

Her spine is stiff as she shifts on her seat. "I don't want anything. I'm fine with ration bars."

"But—"

"Hey!"

They both turn around at the sound of a new voice. Nova Prime's assistant, Elora, stands in the doorway with a sheepish smile. "I hope I'm not interrupting?" Her eyes are only on Quill.

Gamora steals a glance in his direction. His eyes shift to Elora. "Hey. What's up?"

She walks into the room and steps around the chair he's sitting on. Leaning against the edge of the desk, she smiles at Quill excitedly. "Remember when I asked you about those tapes?"

His eyes shift to Gamora and then return to Elora. "Can we talk about this later?"

"Oh." Elora looks at Gamora for the first time. She doesn't look hostile, but she doesn't appear friendly either. Not like she did with Quill. "Are you guys talking about the mission?"

Gamora stands up. "No. We're done."

Quill's eyes widen a little. "What? No."

He places his hands on the chair armrest, as if to get up, but she speaks before he can move. "I'll see you on the ship, Quill."

She then leaves the room.

She knows when she's not welcome. She's never been welcome in her life.

Out, out, out.

She needs to breathe.

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She thinks she can do this until she realizes how bad the sleeping situation is. There's no separate rooms. There's only captain's quarter and *bunks*.

Bunks. There are protective shields but… *bunks*. They mean one thing: sleeping in the same room.

Hearing other people move. Breathe.

The white spots suddenly speckle her vision. The room spins, and her knees get weak. Blindly moving her hands around her, she tries to find anything for support, and when her fingers graze the metal wall, she sags against it, sliding down.

She *can't* do this.

She's good at fighting. She's terrible at everything else.

People. Other people. Many people. She hadn't been surrounded by people since before he destroyed her home world.

On the Sanctuary, her world was made of Thanos, Maw, and Nebula. It was just them—and the victims she tricked, used and killed.

Not *this*. Not *normal* people.

Her skin prickles. Tingles. The numbness spreads everywhere except her chest—there, there's a whirlwind of pain and hatred. Hatred for Thanos. For herself. Anger. Misery.

She tries to breathe. But her lungs collapse in her chest, being pressed on by all those feelings.

Too much. Everything.

Nauseous.

She feels nauseous.

She gets soaked with sweat. Her jacket clings to her skin, and she blindly drags the zipper down, trying to get rid of it.

Hot. Too hot. The air is stuffy.

She recognizes the signs for what they are. Realizing she's spiralling, she presses her palms against the cold metal behind her back. It's not cold enough, but it's the best she's got.

Calm down. Breathe in. Breathe out. Slowly. Deliberately.

You're safe. You're safe. You're safe.

She just doesn't feel like she is.

She doesn't think she can do this.

She *can't* sleep in the same room. She has many walls around her heart—but she needs the real, physical walls around her body too. There *needs* to be a barrier. She doesn't know how to live without one.

Breathe. In and out. In and out.

Her heartbeat slowly comes back to normal. Her vision isn't as sharp as it needs to be, but it's also not completely blurry. The tingling fades away. And when she regains her consciousness, finding herself on the floor, she once again thinks about Quill.

How normal he is.

And how—

How *close*. She hears him clear his throat. She hears his footsteps. Shivers run down her neck because… because those footsteps are almost *right here*.

Her spine tenses. She scrambles up to her feet just in time before he rounds the corner and almost collides with her.

His eyes aren't as bright as they were just a few hours ago. There's something dark, something heavy, but he tries to hide it by wearing a cheerful expression. But it seems too cheerful—almost like it's not cheerful at all. "Hey! I was actually looking for you."

She clears her throat before speaking. "Why?"

"Oh," he shrugs, "I just wanted to offer you to take the captain's quarters."

She's not used to casual offers and free things. It causes nothing but suspicion in her. "Why? You're the captain of the mission. It's your room."

"I mean, yeah. But if it's mine, it means I get to do with it as I please, right? So. I'm offering it to you."

She still doesn't understand. "Why?"

He folds his arms on his chest and casually leans against the wall, ankles crossed. "Why not?"

She doesn't know what to say to that. Mainly because she feels too raw and emotional and she only wants to put some distance between herself and everyone else. *Off-this-ship* kind of distance.

She shakes her head. "Thank you for the offer, but I don't think I'm a good fit for this mission."

His face falls. She's used to seeing this expression when she enters the room, not when she tries to leave. That startles her, makes her swallow thickly. And his expression, this mix of almost… unhappiness? of… disappointment?… it makes her confused.

"You want to leave." It's not a question. She still nods.

He bites the inside of his cheek, almost like he's debating something. "Gamora…"

She steps around him without another word.

"I begged to work with you." His voice is urgent. Practically desperate.

And it's that, together with the actual words, that struck her to her core. A shiver of something dances up her spine. She slowly turns around. "What?"

He pinches the bridge of his nose, looking embarrassed and defeated. He mutters under his nose, "This is not how… Dammit."

Rubbing his face, he then drops his hand to his side. The look he gives her, the depth of his green eyes—it picks her apart. Completely. There's no amusement, there's no smiles, there's no *sun* energy, and yet, she's captivated. Fully. There's no looking away. There's barely even breathing.

It's just his eyes.

"I've always wanted to work with you," he says slowly, his voice deep and quiet. It grips her heart tightly. "But Nova Prime always said no. Said you weren't a team member and she'd never force you. Which… I respected. But I still wanted a chance. And then… then it came."

Her heart beats fast. *I've always wanted to work with you.* "Why?"

"Why what?"

"Why did you want to work with me?"

His brows dip. "Why wouldn't I?" He sounds genuinely surprised. As if that is an obvious, normal thing—to want to work with her.

It's not. It's never been. The sad truth momentarily makes her defenceless against her own walls, against the need to be strong. So she says quietly, "You're the only one."

The look in his eyes hardens. "Then everyone else is a fool."

She blinks. And her lips part. Nothing comes out.

He pushes away from the wall. Takes a step closer to her. Still doesn't look away. She can't either. "What you've done is admirable. I don't think I've ever heard of a braver person. So I wanted to meet you."

Something around her heart cracks. But she doesn't let the gap grow wider. She doesn't let the ice melt away. She reminds herself of the reasons it's there. "Killing innocent people is admirable?"

For a moment, he wears an angry expression, "Don't." But then he takes a breath, erasing the signs of irritation. His eyes fill with compassion. *Compassion*. The air leaves her lungs. "Don't," he repeats, this time softer. "We all have a past, and yours is… you shouldn't have had to survive the way you did." He shakes his head. "It wasn't fair, Gamora, and it wasn't right. But what you did to betray Thanos and stop him? *That* was admirable."

She swallows.

Everything inside her is simply… quiet. Not peacefully quiet. It's *numb*. Because she doesn't know what to say. Or what to do. Or how to react. There's only her galloping heart. And the urge to—

To cry.

As in on command, her eyes burn. She instantly drops her gaze to the ground.

"Selfishly, I want you to stay. A lot." Quill's voice makes her hurt. It makes her breathless. "That's why I want to give you the captain's quarters. I know you don't do teams, and I thought having privacy would make this a little bit easier for you."

She still stays silent. She breathes quickly, in and out, trying to force the tears away.

"But I understand if you want to leave. I don't want to make your life harder."

Her heart clenches.

Quill takes a step away from her. "I'll give you a moment to decide, okay? We'll take off in about ten minutes."

She doesn't acknowledge his words, but she hears them loud and clear.

He steps around her. Then stops. "If you choose to go, I'm still glad we met."

And then he leaves her. She stays rooted in the same place, lost, confused and hopeful. Probably more than ever. She stays there for minutes—until she feels the ship come alive.

Until they're off the ground. Until they're flying away from Xandar.

Until she allows herself to admit the truth she always pushed away.

There *is* curiosity. There *is* longing. There *is* questions. It's always, *How did he move on?* It's always, *Can I?* But it's more than just those things, too. It all comes down to one thing.

Understanding.

No one *ever* understands—but can *he*? A former thief. An ex Ravager. Someone with a grey past. Not as dark as hers—but not pristine white either.

When you've seen the extent of pain and cruelty, can you understand someone else drowning in it?

She hopes, hopes, *hopes*. That leaves her raw. Completely bare.

It becomes so obvious to her then: hope has edges. She just doesn't know if they're sharp or soft.

She just knows they leave her split open.

***

She hides in the privacy of the bedroom until she manages to swallow her emotions down and compose herself enough. After, she squares her shoulders and leaves for the cockpit.

They have to discuss the mission in more detail at some point. Responsibilities. Plan of defence and attack, if it ever comes down to that. She can't hide forever.

But when she nears the stairs leading up to the cockpit, she only hears laughter. *Quill's*. But everyone else's too. It takes her a second to realize that he's telling a story. And the scientists, both of them, are amused. They're practically howling. Reacting. Commenting and asking questions.

Engaging.

Something she can't do. She has nothing to say.

It's impossible to even remember the last time she had a conversation like that.

And there's never been any laughter. Only orders. And threats.

After the betrayal, there was suspicion. Concerns if she was actually good, worthy of trust.

But *not* conversations.

She has been on her own for far too long.

She's struggling in her darkness. Quill thrives in his light.

She's craving to know how. She's terrified to see another proof of her incompetence.

Her stomach feels heavy. Her heart is heavy too. She turns around and goes back to the captain's quarters.

***

When she climbs up the stairs to the cockpit hours later, the scientists are gone. It's just Quill. Something in her relaxes at that. She'd rather deal with one person than three.

“Hey,” she calls softly.

He instantly turns around, and his face lights up. He quickly composes himself, wiping off the expression of delighted surprise, and she appreciates it. She doesn’t want him to make a big deal out of her staying.

She still hasn’t processed *why* she chose to do that.

“Hey,” he says back. “How’s the room?”

She also appreciates him not verbally acknowledging it.

“It’s great, thank you.” Then after a moment she asks, “Are you sure you don’t want it back?”

He makes a face. “I used to be a Ravager. Trust me, it’s not a big deal at all.”

“Okay.”

Silence settles over them, and it’s the uncomfortable kind. That makes her frustrated. She came up here for a *reason*. And yet, even with having something to discuss, she’s struggling to find the right words—or any words, for that matter. How pathetic is that?

Quill points to a seat. “Wanna join me?”

Yes.

She flinches when she hears the voice inside her head. *Damn it. No*.

It’s that *yes* that’s the culprit of her current misery. If only she hadn’t been curious, hopeful, and desperate. But she has joined him—and so far, it’s not working out. She doesn’t need any more signs of how inadequate she is by choosing to stay.

She’s here for business.

So she shakes her head, “I came up here to discuss our strategy.”

“Oh?”

She folds her arms on her chest and shifts her weight to her left side. “When we land, I don’t think it’s wise for all of us to sleep at night. We could be attacked any moment, so I think someone always needs to keep watch.”

Quill nods in agreement. “I was thinking the same.”

It shouldn’t matter that he’s thinking the same things. It *shouldn’t*. And yet…

She clears her throat. “I can keep watch at night. This way, you get to sleep and accompany the scientists during the day.”

Quill takes a moment to react. He leans forward a little. “You want to do it this way?”

Something about his tone makes her uneasy. It's too deep. Too considerate. Too *something*. It's not just a simple question. It's loaded—as if he understands something that he shouldn't.

She doesn't want him to understand. There's no need for him to know this plan is meant to keep her safe and sane. She doesn't want to interact with anyone. She simply wants to do her job.

Her protecting everyone at night gives her exactly that.

Quill's eyes are dark in the dim light, but they're still full of things she doesn't want to see. She clears her throat, trying to sound nonchalant. "Yes, I do."

He holds her gaze and then gives her an easy smile, and she has a feeling it's more reassuring —for her own good—than truly sincere. She hates it. She's also grateful. She'll take a fake way out of this. "Sure. We can do it this way."

She still can't help but ask, "You don't mind?"

He's already given up his bedroom. If he wants to keep watch at night, she doesn't want him to be robbed of the chance.

"Nah," he waves his hand. "I'm good with this plan."

It's foolish to have thought otherwise. Why wouldn't he be? He's good with people. There's no need for him to hide from anyone.

She rocks on her heels. "Okay, then."

She turns around and takes two steps down when he calls her, "Gamora?"

She looks at him over his shoulder. His eyes are serious. When he speaks, his voice is a murmur, "I'm glad you stayed." It's also tender. Quiet.

For a moment, she freezes. A second later, her mind is a foggy mess. And she doesn't mean to say anything, she really doesn't, and yet, she admits, "I wanted to work with you too."

At that, his eyes widen in surprise. "Really?"

Her body recoils in embarrassment. *What has she done?* Mortified, she regrets the words right away, but the ghost of the barely hidden hope on his face is too earnest, too *honest* for her to ignore. A muscle twitches in her leg, her body ready to run, but she finds the courage to say, "Really."

The admission feels dangerous, like something that could be used against her. *Will be* used against her. So her entire soul reaches for fear, wrapping it around herself tightly, and she manages to choke out, "I'll be here for my watch in a few hours," and then she practically stumbles down the stairs.

***

In the morning, she retreats back into the bedroom as soon as she hears everyone else wake up.

***

She manages to avoid them the next day too.

***

Then her luck runs out. She's half asleep and emotionally spent, so she doesn't even realize that someone's in the kitchen. When her brain processes the sounds of the three voices, it's too late.

She's already made herself seen.

At the sight of all of them sitting around the kitchen table and eating dinner, *together*, she freezes. Everyone's eyes on her make her feel seen in a way she doesn't like.

"Uh, hi," she says awkwardly.

The scientists give her a weak smile. But Quill's smile a real one. A wide one. "Hey! Would you like to join us?"

She doesn't want to do that. And yet, it still breaks her heart to see a ghost of a frown on one of the scientist's face. It's gone before it can become something that's impossible to hide, but she's used to these expressions. She's used to people reacting weirdly around her.

The message is loud and clear.

Her own smile is forced. She lifts up her clothes and waves it a little. "Uh… I was going to take a shower?" She doesn't know why the statement comes out as a question. But it does.

She pretends it has nothing to do with wanting to soften her rejection. She chooses to ignore a spark of disappointment on Quill's face. He recovers quickly, though. After a brief moment, he gives her another reassuring smile—that kind that's meant for her, not a show of his genuine happiness. "Sure. Next time, then."

She nods. Passing through the kitchen, she rounds the corner, ready to keep on walking, but then stops. Presses her back to the wall and listens.

They don't talk about her. But they discuss tomorrow.

"What are you guys gonna do? Another sampling trip?" Quill asks.

"Yes," Calea says. "We need to figure out why this soil is so rich. So far, it's a mystery."

"We were thinking about going further into the forest, though," the other scientist adds.

They keep on talking about that, but Gamora spaces out a little bit. She suddenly realizes that she doesn't know the name of the second scientist. She has also never asked them about their

plans.

She has never asked *anyone* about their plans.

How can she ever hope be more than a killing machine when she can't even show her interest?

***

It's late at night, the ship is quiet, when she opens the fridge, hungry. Her eyes immediately land on a plate of snazzberries, and before she can stop herself, excitement makes her reach for the plate.

It's one of the very few fruits she's tried. She loves it, but it's impossible to peel, and she finds that it's rarely worth the effort. The deep purple colour stains her fingers, and the skin of the fruit is sticky, hard to wash off. It's only when she pulls the plate out of the fridge that she comes to her senses.

No one in their right mind would ever peel the fruit and leave it for someone else.

Someone peeled it for themselves.

Her excitement disappears in a second. Feeling her face fall, she intends to put the plate back on the shelf, when she hears a voice behind her. "You can eat it."

She whips her head around. She doesn't need to, she knows the voice, but she still chooses to look at him.

He doesn't look half-asleep. He looks like he hasn't gone to bed at all. There are dark bags under his eyes, and he looks tired. There's also a… gash on his upper arm?

She nods toward it. "What's that?"

He looks down, seemingly confused. When he sees the cut, he simply shrugs, unbothered, "We ran into some plants. They weren't too happy with people around, so one of them got me."

He got hurt—and she didn't know. She *wouldn't* know. He's wearing a short-sleeve shirt now, but whenever they see each other during the day, he always wear long-sleeves. The strange irritation—at the plant, at herself—makes her swallow thickly. "Does it hurt?"

"No," he says lightly, and she thinks he's telling the truth. He doesn't seem troubled at all. Tired—but not worried.

She's placated—just a little bit. But the intensity of her irritation doesn't decrease. If anything, it only grows. It's like an itch under her skin, but when she scratches her arm, it doesn't help.

It takes her a long moment to realize she's feeling *concern*. And guilt. While she's familiar with the latter, the former makes her stomach churn. She *has* felt it before, but it has always

been a very generic, hypothetical feeling. She *was* worried for nameless victims of Thanos' plans—and it was that concern that made her finally act—but… She can't remember being concerned for a *specific* person.

The realization makes her exhale, the sound quiet but loaded.

Quill doesn't miss it. He looks like he wants to ask, but he stops himself before he can. Instead, he nods toward the plate in her hand again and repeats, "You can have it if you want."

She looks down briefly, the idea of food repelling now. "Is it yours?"

"Yeah."

She should have asked him about his day. She should have *tried*. Instead, she chose to hide in the bedroom until they all went to bed. Now, he's offering her his food. She can't eat it.

"No, thank you. I'm… I'm not hungry."

Her stomach chooses to make a loud sound that second. Quill raises his eyebrow, amused. "You sure about that?"

She might be bad at many things, but she's good at being stubborn. "Yes."

He gives her an all-knowing look, calling her out without words. But then something in his gaze changes. The shift is practically instant. Any signs of amusement fade away, and he looks almost contrite. Or… frustrated? With… her?

He points behind her. "Uh… I was just going to grab some water, I didn't mean to disturb you. I'll be out of your way in a second."

He steps around her and fills a glass with water. Without drinking it first, he starts walking back the way he came. She watches him go, not hearing anything that would sound like, *Later, then*, and her stomach churns.

He's never shown signs of wanting to get away from her. Not until now. But she *has* seen the discomfort in his eyes.

She never thought she would be affected seeing that.

She is.

A dark, uncomfortable feeling bubbles up inside her. She knows it well, having familiarized herself with it a long time ago. Self-preservation. It screams at her to be quiet, to let him leave.

A much sharper, much more uncomfortable feeling presses against her diaphragm, too. *Hope.* It screams at her to say something. To follow up on the intent she felt last night. *Show interest. Interact.*

Her muscles are seized by fear, something as devitalizing as the first time she felt it. But the hope inside her grows, pressing firmer and firmer against her body organs—and the words are simply pushed out. “Would you like to share it?”

He turns his head right away. His expression is almost chary, and she *despises* it. She regrets her words right away, so she says quickly, “You don’t have to stay if you don’t want to.”

“I want to,” he argues softly. “I just don’t want to make you uncomfortable.”

She’s *always* uncomfortable. But she asks, unsure, “What?”

His words are careful. “I know… I know you value your own time. I didn’t want to impose on that.” He takes a sip of water. “I wasn’t sure if you didn’t want to eat with me in the room, so…” His voice trails off.

She blinks at him. She jumped to the worst case scenario—because it’s all she’s ever known—while he was… thinking of her? She stomps down the thought, unable to process it in the moment, and simply says, “No.”

“No?”

“You weren’t imposing,” she clarifies. Which, she suddenly realizes, is true. She runs away from him every time—but he *never* imposes. He never disturbs. He does the opposite—and *this* thought is stomped down too.

His eyes light up. The heaviness disappears, and he turns to face her fully. “So… you don’t mind me staying?”

She does. She doesn’t. “No, I don’t.”

He looks *happy*. And she’s suddenly afraid he knows how to read between the lines. How to hear what’s left unsaid. How else would the three simple words cause his eyes to light up? Her discomfort flares up, but something else, something equally dark and light, quickens her pulse regardless.

Hope. Still. *Always*. It’s sharp. It *slices*. But somehow, it doesn’t make her bleed.

“Wanna sit down then?” He offers.

“Yes.”

***

The next day, when they come back from another trip to the jungle, she doesn’t hide in the bedroom. She waits for them in the cockpit.

When Quill climbs up the stairs and finds her there, his smile breaks his face in two. “Hey!”

She gives him a glance over. There’s no new injuries. She lets out a breath she was holding. “Hey.”

She tries to give him a smile. She doesn't know if it works, her muscles aren't used to that, but she's making an effort.

She's also making an effort when she asks, "How did today go?"

The words feel foreign on her tongue, and she feels awkward asking something so simple. But when Quill jumps into an animated replay of the events, she feels herself relax a little.

***

When she opens the fridge that night, she finds a plate of snazzberries with a note next to it.

For you.

***

He does the same thing the night after that.

***

She doesn't know which fruits are his favourite—she still hasn't eaten with them—but she chooses a safe bet: more snazzberries. It takes her almost half an hour to peel all the fruits she pulled out of the fridge. It takes her another half an hour to scrub her fingers clean and to remove the skin of the fruit from the counter. It really doesn't need much time to dry and glue itself to anything it touches.

She absolutely despises the cleaning process.

But when she dumps the cut pieces into a huge container, she feels a spark of foolish satisfaction.

She doesn't want Quill to read between the lines. She also does. The idea terrifies and thrills her at the same time.

That morning, she goes to bed early, before they wake up.

***

When she wakes up in the early afternoon and goes to take a shower, she finds a note attached to the door of her room.

Thank you.

***

A loud sound startles her enough that she abruptly sits up on the bed, her fingers instinctively wrapping around the hilt of the Godslayer under her pillow. She has to blink a few times to push the sleepiness away, trying to become fully conscious, and only then realizes that the sound is a knock on the door.

Getting out of bed, she doesn't let go of the sword. No one has ever knocked before. She doesn't think an intruder would ever announce their presence, but she doesn't want to take any chances.

Pushing her hair out of her face, she unlocks the door. When she opens it, Quill's bright eyes greet her. He winces at the sight of her, looking guilty.

"I'm so sorry to wake you, I know you just went to bed. But Calea thinks there will be a storm tomorrow, and she wants to go further into the jungle today. We could use another guard."

Oh.

She doesn't know what her face shows, but Quill looks remorseful. "I know teams aren't your thing, but I wouldn't ask if it wasn't important. That part of the jungle is full of carnivorous plants."

Oh.

Just once sentence—and she's not weirdly numb anymore. A buzz of concern tingles at the base of her spine. Carnivorous plants. Quill having to protect two people. That scratch that she remembers on his shoulder. The sleep immediately fades away, and she's alert.

"Give me five minutes," she tells him. "I'll meet you out front."

He looks grateful. "Thank you."

***

She's faced worse, much worse, but she feels her eyes widen at the size of the plants. Twice as tall as she is. The stem is almost as wide and thick as Quill's thighs are—and she doesn't even know how to justify the thought. She shouldn't have that compassion in her mind. But she does. Because she's seen.

Stared, in a way. Which she did refuse to admit to herself in the moment. And she's refusing to admit now—except that she can't even think of anything else.

Her cheeks burn. Her skin erupts in cold chills, embarrassment making her breathe faster. She knows it's impossible for anyone to read thoughts, but she's irrationally terrified that someone will know.

Trying to push the thought away, she thinks of Thanos. That does the trick, and her stomach drops in fear this time.

Slowly—and quietly—they creep further into the jungle. And soon, the more they walk, the more of those plants she sees. They get bigger as well. Eventually, there's no other trees, no other plants. It's just these sensitive to the touch monster machines that could eat them all in a second. They tower over them, surround them on both sides, and Gamora feels a nervous buzz in her entire body.

Whatever the scientists need to collect better be worth it.

Her hold on the Godslayer tightens. Quill also doesn't seem to be too comfortable. She can see him from the corner of her eyes, and his arms are raised high, ready to fire his blasters. He reacts to every single sound, watching the stems that lightly sway above them with narrowed eyes.

When they finally reach a creek, Calea drops to her knees, her fingers immediately disappearing under water, digging something out. The guy—Murom, Gamora learned—follows her suit.

No one says a word. Gamora walks around the scientists, placing herself between them and the plants. Quill takes a stance on the opposite side.

The air is heavy. Anticipation builds up in her chest.

She isn't sure how much time passes. She's only aware of the faint rustling sound of the leaves. The humidity in the air slowly gets to her, and sweat builds up on her neck, below the hairline. It also trickles down her spine. She regrets wearing a leather jacket.

If she wasn't too focused on gripping the sword, she would take it off. But she doesn't want to lose her focus even for a moment.

The stems practically float around in the air—even though there's no wind that would cause them to move. Normally, they don't move too far from, don't get in other stems' way, and it's almost hypnotizing to watch the leaves rustle and flutter.

Until it isn't. Until it gets terrifying.

One stem moves too far. It touches the other plant.

And suddenly, the leaf that was flat and harmless splits itself in two and sinks its newfound teeth into the attacking stem. A loud shrill follows, and Gamora's eyes widen when she realizes it's the plant that wails.

"Guys…" Quill's voice is loaded with everything she's thinking.

They need to go. Now.

No one moves.

She watches the two plants fight in horror. In morbid fascination too. They thrash around, convulsing, screeching, but then… Then they touch the plants around them.

The chain reaction follows.

In a second, every plant she can see is fighting, playing the role of either the prey or the predator. The jungle around them comes to life, screeching sounds and loud shrills coming from every direction.

Her stomach drops.

The plants are above them. They are around them.

Her breath comes out in a shallow pant. It doesn't matter which plants are biting the other plants.

They are the real prey in here.

"Guys," Quill's voice raises, panic and urgency making it deeper and higher at the same time. "We have to get going. *Now*."

She doesn't wait this time. She doesn't hesitate. She turns around, roughly grabs Calea by her elbow and tugs her up. Quill helps Murom, and then they all run.

The adrenaline takes over her. She doesn't hear anything but the rush of the blood.

She ducks down.

She throws her body to the side to avoid collision with the thrashing stems.

The leaves are all split open.

Teeth. She can only see *teeth*. They're all the size of her palm.

She keeps on running, her sword raised high. The walk that took an hour at a leisurely pace now feels like something that has no end.

They *can't* escape this.

It's too much.

The traps are everywhere.

Calea, trying to avoid collision with three stems that are ripping each other apart, grazes another stem with her shoulder.

"No!" Gamora yells. "Move!"

But it's *too* late.

She throws her body forward, pushing Calea and herself to the ground. They land onto the grass, tangled together, and a sharp pain pierces Gamora's hip. She lets out a cry.

"Gamora!" Quill yells.

She doesn't have time to react. She doesn't have time to do anything. She only has time to push Calea away. Then, the stem plows toward her, and—

She *wails*.

The sharp teeth bite into her thigh, and she's blinded by the pain. The white specks muddle her vision, and she *knows* she has to cut the stem, she *knows* she has to use the Godlsayer, she *knows* she has to fight—but she *can't*.

Pain. Pain. Pain. Pain. Pain. Pain.

Everywhere.

And then—

Then something feels *wrong*.

She manages to peel her eyes open—but that's all she can do. The world has dimmed. It's blurry. It's *tilting* and *swaying* and *dancing*. There's…

There's four of everything?

Four stems? *Four stems…*

Need to… slice… through…

But…

Pain…

And…

D-dark… Wh-why is it so dark…

Dark. And then—darkness.

chapter 2

Well, hold on, my darling
This mess was yours
Now your mess is mine

She comes to her senses slowly. At first, nothing makes sense. She tires to blink, tries to figure out what she's feeling, *where* she is—but everything is blurry.

Slow. Her brain is *slow.*

She coughs. Her mouth feels dry. Why?

What happened?

She can't remember.

She coughs again and tries to sit up. The world swims and spins around her, and she feels a sliver of panic.

Something is wrong.

"Hey. Hey. It's okay."

She doesn't recognize the voice right away, but she *knows* it. It's warm, and it makes her wonder.

Peter Quill.

"Would you like some water?"

She nods. A second later, she feels his fingers come to contact with her side, helping her sit up. Something touches her lips. A… cup? She wraps her lips around the rim and takes a sip.

The water going down her throat soothes the burning feeling in it.

She takes a few more sips. When she's done, she tries to blink again. This time, the blurriness goes away, just a little bit. It's suddenly replaced by Peter Quill's worried face. It's close, it's *right here*, and she inhales sharply.

"Wh-what happened?"

He moves away, pulling the cup with himself. She watches it, almost hungrily, and he must notice. "I'm just going to leave it here, okay?" He places it on a bedside table.

She *knows* this table. She also recognizes the wall behind Quill.

Bedroom. She's in the bedroom.

The familiar site triggers recognition, and suddenly everything comes back too.

“The plants… We…” She doesn’t finish.

“We got away,” Quill says. “I… I thought you wouldn’t make it.” There’s a shadow flashing across his face. “You were injured badly. When we hooked you up to the machines, it said there was poison in your blood. From the bite… and…”

Poison. She hates what Thanos did to her body, she’s always hated it, but the mods have kept her alive for so many years. He might have ruined her life, but at least, he gave her something useful.

“But… the poison… your body somehow fought it. Even before we had done anything.”

“I have a regeneration implant.” It’s an effort to talk, still, so she reaches for the cup.

Quill beats her to it by grabbing the cup and brining it to her lips. She takes a sip, almost too compliantly, suddenly stunned by the realization: she doesn’t hate it, his help. She would have hated anyone else’s. She’s survived on her own just fine, after all. But his eyes are full of dark, grim horror, and she doesn’t fight him.

She doesn’t know why.

Once the cup is empty, he asks, his voice unsure, “Regeneration implant?”

She knows it’s unwise to tell anyone anything about her body—even the most simple act can be used against her—but she ignores the precautions. “Thanos modified my body when I was a child.”

Quill’s eyes fill with alarm. “He did *what*?” There’s no curiosity. There’s just barely hidden dread.

She nods stiffly. “I have a cybernetic skeleton, improved neurological system, and a bunch of implants. He needed me to be strong.” *Invincible* was the word he used. And yet, she wasn’t. Because she could be—and *was*—defeated by him.

She wishes he worked on the part of her brain that was responsible for emotions.

Quill swallows thickly. “Is… are these scars from that?”

She immediately turns away from him. The scars are *right there*, impossible not to notice. But it’s different when they’re pointed at. It makes it hard to pretend she’s not damaged.

Her silence must be an answer enough because Quill mutters quietly, “Jesus… Gamora…”

“I’m fine.”

Silence. And then quiet murmur, full of pained sympathy, “Are you?”

The question catches her off guard. Her lips part, embarrassment clawing up at her throat, and she tries to swallow around a lump. “He’s no longer a threat. Of course I’m fine.”

Quill’s voice is tentative, almost as if he’s unsure if he’s allowed to say anything. “It’s okay to not be fine. You went through *hell*.”

She shifts a little. “I *put* people through hell.” She doesn’t get to talk about suffering. Not when she *caused* it. Her own pain is the price she has to pay for the lives she had to take.

Quill’s voice is more vehement now. “You tried to *survive*.”

Survive? And for what? To still not be normal? Not much of a life, is it?

The cold feeling spreads through her body. “I don’t want to talk about it.”

“Gamora—”

“Enough.” Her voice is sharp.

The silence is tense for a long moment. Quill’s exhale is long and hard, and she practically flinches, suddenly wanted to disappear. The sound resembles disappointment a lot. Abrupt fear practically chokes her: is this the end?

Defensiveness follows the fear—it shouldn’t matter if this is the end. It shouldn’t matter if he’s disappointed. She’s survived without his approval just fine.

Except that she hasn’t, and she blurts out, dismayed, “I…” But she doesn’t finish. She doesn’t know what to say. She doesn’t know how to erase his disappointment.

She hates that she wants to do that. She hates that she wants him to be on her side. So many people hate her, still, *always*, but *he*… he’s never looked at her in disgust. He’s sent a little bit of light her way—and suddenly she’s craving more.

“I’m sorry.” Her voice is unrecognizable to her own ears.

Humiliated, she closes her eyes. She isn’t begging—but she *is*.

“Hey, no,” he says immediately. “Don’t apologize.”

She steals a glance in his direction. He doesn’t look offended by her sharp tone—or cruelly amused by her broken whisper.

Still, she says, “My tone wasn’t nice.” *And you sighed. Tiredly.*

He only shakes his head. “You let me know your boundary. *After* I tried to push. I’m the one who needs to apologize. So… I’m sorry.”

She only blinks at him, dazed. He’s not… upset? The echo of disappointment she thought she heard a moment ago is nowhere to be found now. So she blurts out exactly what she’s thinking—or *was* thinking, “But you *sighed*.”

“I… I did,” he nods slowly, almost cautiously. He doesn’t explain.

And the buzz under her skin gets unbearable. “Why?”

He lets out another sigh, looking doomed and uncomfortable. Her discomfort grows. Before she can spiral, though, he finally says, “Because it kills me that you see yourself in that light. And every time I realize that you do, I want to fight you, but I don’t want to anger you either. That sigh was me being at a crossroad.”

She thinks her lips part in shock, but she’s not entirely sure. Her mind is a muddy mess, and she only exhales. She doesn’t even know where to begin deciphering his statement, her mind latching onto separate words in a futile attempt to process the meaning. *Kills me. That light. Fight you. Anger. Crossroad.*

Stunned, she mutters, “I thought you were done.”

“Done?” He frowns a little.

She doesn’t say, *With me*. But maybe he realizes that anyways because his face lengthens. “No,” he says immediately. “Absolutely not. I simply regretted pushing you too far while wishing I could make you believe me.”

Believe me. Disbelief knots in her stomach. And then, self-consciousness joins it. Was she supposed to understand that? Was she supposed to know the difference between what she thought was happening and what was actually happening?

She swallows past a lump in her throat.

She really doesn’t understand feelings. She thought she knew how to read body language, but there’s more to look out for than the preemptive quivering and tensing of muscles before one chooses to strike. There’s different degrees of sighing too. Who could have known?

Then again, probably everyone.

She doesn’t know what prompts her to reveal her own shortcomings to him. “I’m not good with emotions.” She sounds apprehensive. She *is* apprehensive. Her heart beats wildly in her chest. “I’m sorry.” He opens his mouth to say something, so she interrupts him before he can. “But I still don’t want to talk about it.”

His mouth snaps closed. He gives her a nod. He clasps his hands together. “Would you like me to leave?”

No. She doesn’t even have to think twice about her answer. Biting the inside of her cheek, she shakes her head quickly.

This time, his exhale sounds a lot like relief. But she doesn’t trust herself anymore—*scared* to trust this time, afraid to get burned—so she pushes the thought away.

“Do you want to talk about something else or would you prefer not to talk?”

Her courage was used up to let him know she wants him to stay. She doesn't think she can carry out a conversation—too many chances to realize her own inadequacy, too many chances to feel wrong. And yet, "What are we going to do if not talk?" She frowns.

His small smile is warm. Blinding. He shifts his hips a little and then pulls out a device she's seen him use before. He holds it up, looking proud. "That's what music is for."

"Music," she repeats.

He nods eagerly. "Yes! We can listen to it, if you'd like?"

The innocence of the offer makes her stomach churn. She's never listened to music before, not unless it was played in the establishments she visited for missions. Another common experience that she failed to live.

Quill's face falls. "We don't have to listen to music, if you don't want to."

She doesn't like when his face falls. Not when she's the reason. "No, I want to." Her voice is thick.

He doesn't look convinced. "Are you sure? You didn't seem… too excited."

"No, I… I am. I just…" she shrugs. Then mumbles, almost too quiet for him to hear, "I've never listened to music before."

But he does hear her. His eyes widen a little, but he masks his surprise quickly. Instead of giving her a weird glance, he only gives her an encouraging smile. "It's your lucky day, then. I happen to have excellent taste and can introduce you to the greatest hits ever produced."

"The greatest hits?" She repeats, slightly dubious. But nicely dubious. She doesn't want to offend him. There's a ghost of smile on her lips.

"The greatest hits," he confirms with a nod. He looks down, pressing on a button on the device.

While he's busy doing that, she glances down. The memories of the attack are bright in her mind and she knows her body most likely have already healed itself completely, given that she's in no pain at all, but she still lifts up the blanket to check the injury.

Where she should see the pants she only sees green skin. Mortified, she makes a stifled sound.

"We had to cut away your pants," Quill says, voice regretful. "It was the only way to work with the wound. I'm… I'm sorry."

"N-no… It's… uh, okay."

She's not *entirely* naked. They haven't removed her pants completely, just pant legs, turning it into shorts. But she's still significantly more undressed than she's ever been in front of anyone.

She swallows. And then immediately plows ahead, not knowing how to react to the sight of her skin. To the knowledge that others—*Quill*—have seen it. Unwrapping the bandage to distract herself, she finds no wound underneath. No scarring either.

Her skin is smooth, like never touched.

Once again, she's saddened by the reality of her life. Thanos made sure her body could survive anything. He never thought about her heart.

"How's the wound looking?" Quill asks.

"It's gone."

He blinks. "Gone *gone*?"

Well, maybe the wound is gone, but her body must *still* be dealing with the aftermath of the injury; there's no other way to explain why she chooses to push the blanket aside. *To show* Quill the wound side. *After* being struck by the realization he saw her legs.

His eyes zero in on one specific spot. Disbelief flashes across his face, his lips falling apart a little. "But…"

She drags the blanket up to cover herself. "Regeneration implant," she shrugs.

His frown doesn't disappear. "I know you said you had it but… You can't even *guess* you were hurt. It's just…" He doesn't finish.

Her smile is sad now. "He liked his assets perfect."

Quill's lips press into a tight line. Anger mars his features. And his voice, so vehement, so deep, is full of loathing, "I hate him for what he did to you."

Her heart skips a beat. Her stomach feels warm. So she whispers, "I hate him too."

The words are so obvious—but she's never said them out loud. She thought them, every second, every day, but she's never voiced them. A sliver of satisfaction takes her by surprise. She never thought voicing the truth would be so nice.

The feeling is so addictive that she can't stop the next words. "He orphaned me. He imprisoned me. He ruined my life. I'm happy that he's gone, but I hate it at the same time. He didn't deserve such an easy way out. He deserved to suffer."

She looks up at Quill and sees him push the device between his leg and the side of the chair. She doesn't comment on that. Suddenly, she wants nothing more than to talk. To hear what *he* thinks.

He leans forward, his elbows on his knees, chin propped on his fingers. He looks lost and determined at the same time. "I… I don't know what to say," he says, almost apologetic. "Not because I don't have anything to say," he adds hurriedly, "but because nothing I could

ever say would be adequate. You… you went through hell. And I'm just… so sorry." His eyes hold hers. "You didn't deserve any of that. You just… didn't."

His voice isn't full of pity. There's something more, something deeper. Something she doesn't recognize at first. Not until he says, "I… I understand though. Wishing he suffered more. When I killed my biological father, I…" his sigh is almost chocked. "I just… *get it*."

And then *she* does. Because he *understands* her. He knows what it's like to hate someone so much you're happy that they're gone. He knows what it's like to hate them so much you wish they stayed longer—just so you could inflict even an ounce of pain you felt.

He *understands* her. The realization makes her shiver. The sudden, acute urge to share everything with him hits her in a wave. She has to stand her ground, tensing all of her muscles, especially those in her throat, to wait for the wave to pass.

But even when it does, it's not gone completely.

"I'm sorry too," she offers, hating the depth of his scars. "I know Ego killed your mother."

Quill's surprised by that. "You do?"

She nods reluctantly. "I overheard that particular conversation. You were talking to Dey, and I was on my way to see Nova Prime."

"I didn't know you even knew about me before the mission."

She can't hold a solemn snort in.

"What?" He asks.

If only he knew how aware of him she's been for a very long time. But she shakes her head, "Nothing."

Except that he doesn't drop the subject. "When did you learn about me?"

Her cheeks burn all of a sudden. Hesitant, she chews on her lower lip, and Quill immediately says, "It's okay. We don't have to talk about it."

And *tha*t, this option to escape, prompts her to share. "Thanos was… smart." It pains her to give him anything resembling a compliment. "He knew there were three powerful beings who could… um, if not stop him, then resist him. He didn't want that."

Quill frowns. "Who were those people?"

"The Ancient One, Odin and… Ego."

"Ego?" Quill echoes, clearly taken aback.

She nods. "He was powerful enough to cause problems for Thanos. So… I had been aware of Ego for a very long time, ever since I first researched all of them. And… I'd known about his

dead children for a while too." Another thing she feels guilty about. She could have done something—but she chose not to. Swallowing, she continues. "I also heard a rumour that his child, the one who possesses celestial abilities, must be out there."

She sees the unasked question in Quill's eyes. "I didn't know the child was you," she shakes her head. "It was only when you killed him, essentially setting Thanos' plans in motions that I—"

"*What?*" Quill's eyes widen. Then the realization hits him. "Because Ego was gone… Thanos felt… compelled to start?"

She makes a face, "Kind of? He still wasn't going to strike, aware of the other two, but he definitely was going to—and *started*—working on his plans more actively. He went from simply theorizing, or doing the bare minimum, to preemptively doing things."

Quill lets out a sigh. "I…"

His face darkens. He hangs his head low, and she isn't sure what he's thinking or feeling, but she thinks she catches a glimpse of self-deprecating judging. It's something she sees in the mirror often. She doesn't want him to feel it. She doesn't want his light to be dimmed. "When you killed Ego, that's when I became aware of you. I researched you then." A lot. More she should have ever done. "I felt… inspired." It feels dangerous to admit the truth.

But she thinks it's worth it when Quill's head shoots back up. "What?"

"I was thinking that… if you could… defeat an absolute monster, then maybe…" *I could do too.* That was her thinking. That was her reasoning. She doesn't finish the sentence, her tongue not listening to her. "You were alone that day, and you stopped him. So I… I thought that if maybe I had the Nova Corps help, maybe I would be able to stop Thanos too."

Quill just stares at her. She feels uncomfortable as his eyes pick her apart, staring straight into her soul, and the silence weighs down on her so strongly that she starts talking again.

"You made me want to do something." Her cheeks burn. "For the first time in my life, I learned that someone powerful could be opposed. Defeated, even. That made me want to try."

You made me want to try. She just doesn't say the words. She can't.

But she's thinking them. Always.

He used to be a thief—and then he became a hero. He got kidnapped—and then he found a way to be okay. He was an example of turning his life around—and back then, she wanted nothing more.

She hadn't even known about his mother then. When she learned the truth, everything she felt for him only grew. Intensified.

Respect. Admiration. Jealousy.

He's strong, and he's *normal*. She's the opposite. And yet, she's been trying to shorten the invisible distance between who they are every day.

He still doesn't say anything. And the storm in her chest grows. She shifts a little, wanting to bolt, regretting ever opening her mouth, when he finally whispers, his voice reverent and almost chocked, "You're amazing."

She thinks she chokes too. "What?"

"*You* stopped him, Gamora. We both know the Nova Corps could have never done that without your intel, your help, so it was *you* who saved the entire universe. You were brave, you were strong, and you *stopped* him, and yet… you sit here and talk about *me*. When you should be praising yourself. So I will say what you won't: you're amazing."

Everything inside her twists. "No one else sees it that way."

And if they don't, they must be right. When has the majority been wrong?

"Then screw them." Quill—*Peter*—practically spats. "If they're stupid or blind to not see the truth, it's not your problem."

"But—"

"Don't trust them. Trust *me*." It's almost a plea. A dangerous one. One that makes her think and feel, and she falls silent. Breathless. "You and I, we've known ugly truths for so long. But *this* truth, Gamora? This one is beautiful."

Beautiful.

Weird, unknown tenderness settles over her very quickly. It reaches deep inside her, spreading through her entire body, and the pressure makes her draw her legs close to her chest. She presses her thighs into the material of her shirt, trying to oppose the force that threatens to split her into million pieces.

"I'm afraid everyone will always see me as nothing but a loyal lackey to him." That is one of the many names she's heard in her address. One of the nicest one too.

"You *aren't*," Peter immediately says. Then he rolls his lower lip inside his mouth, looking unsure. "Someone called you that?"

"Among other things."

His eyes flash with something dark, something wild. "Assholes." His palms curl into fists. "Is that… is that one of the reasons you don't do teams?"

She gives him a short, stiff nod. It's much harder to get hurt when you're on your own. Then again, it's much easier too. When there's nothing but pain and thoughts, you can't help but feel and think.

"Can I share something?" Quill asks. Then amends, "Admit, actually."

She tenses. “What?”

He sits up and rubs his neck, appearing hesitant for a moment. “I wasn’t spying on you, I promise. I just happened to walk in on you.”

Her fingers grip the blanket. She needs something to ground herself. His words, his apprehension—she only grows more nervous with each second.

“I saw you before we took off. When you had a panic attack."

Oh. She exhales quietly, instantly numb inside. A second later, she’s not numb at all. Irritation. Shame. Anger. Embarrassment. Everything swirls, everything chokes, and then everything goes away. Numbness returns. She only blinks.

“I had them too,” he admits, “so it was easy to recognize what was happening. I’d wanted to give you the quarters anyway, but that moment I *knew* I would do it. I didn’t know what caused the attack, but I was hoping some privacy would help you.”

She clears her throat. “Why are you telling me this?”

He doesn’t reply for a long moment. And then, “Because you matter, Gamora.”

A puff of air escapes her lips. Surprise. Desperation. *Need*. All of the dark parts of her soul, of her mind, suddenly want to be basked in light. Peter’s light.

“Because you deserve to know the truth,” he continues. “I don’t want to lie to you—or omit something important. You looked like you needed space, and I wanted to give it to you. You deserve people who think about you in your corner. I want to be in it.”

Thanos always gave direct orders, so she never had to learn how to hear what lingered between words. She’s unable to process the words she’s hearing now.

Her lips part.

“I never want to be dismissive like other people, Gamora. I never want to make you uncomfortable or push the boundaries, so I appreciate that you stopped me earlier. Whatever you want to let me know, I will be happy to learn, okay?” His green eyes warm a little. “I like learning things about you.”

I like learning things about you. Her body doesn’t know how to react. She feels cold, she feels hot, everything leaps up but also falls down. Her heart is equally in her stomach and in her throat.

Peter smile is warm and sheepish. “I don’t want to overwhelm you. I’m sorry. I just… I want you to know. That I’m here. To listen. Or talk. Or… anything. Okay?”

I’m here.

It’s Peter Quill. And now, *I’m here.*

Hope flutters. Hope grows. And now, it feels like the warmest blanket—the kind that saves even when you sleep on the floor. She doesn't fight the shivers that run down her neck, her spine.

She feels seen—and it's nerve wrecking. But she's seen by Peter Quill, and somehow, he makes it okay. He makes it less scary.

He makes her feel like she's not alone. For the first time in her life, she feels like someone sees beyond the lives she ruined and the sins she committed. Like someone sees her. The ugly, the uglier, and the darkest. He sees it—and still gives her a smile. It takes her breath away.

So she doesn't say anything. But she gives him a nod. And smiles back.

At the sight of her smile, his own gets wider.

They stare at one another for what feels like forever. But when the burning in her cheeks gets unbearable, she drops her gaze down. Bites the inside of her cheek. Feels the way her heart races in her chest.

And then—

Then she hears how wildly his heart races too.

Not alone. Right this moment, she's truly not alone. The realization jolts her, and she feels *safe*.

Her cheeks burn more.

"Would you still like to listen to music?" He asks her.

She nods right away. She doesn't want him to leave.

Looking up, she watches him grab the discarded device. Pressing on the screen, he then looks at her. "Any requests?"

"I don't know any songs," she reminds him.

"I know," he agrees easily, not making a huge deal out of her reminder. "But what are you in the mood for?"

She thinks about it for a moment. "Something happy."

He doesn't think much of her answer, but she's surprised by it. She never thought she would make such request. She never thought she would feel light.

He tugs some wire, and with a soft pop, it disconnects from the device. "I just thought we could listen without earphones," he explains.

She's grateful for clarification.

She slides a little bit lower, settling in more comfortably. Looking at Peter, she doesn't think he's enjoying the chair too much; it looks almost too small for him.

"Are you comfortable?" She asks.

"Mhm?"

"The chair. Is it comfortable?"

He simply waves her off. "I've had worse."

She doesn't like the answer. But the alternatives are the bed—or for him to leave the room. She's not a fan of either. She swallows her protests, equally touched and frustrated. She's glad he's choosing to stay. She's annoyed with herself for being selfish.

A melody fills the room. And she somehow loses herself in it. In *this*. In Peter's presence, in this room, in the bubble they've constructed around themselves. She soaks everything up, fills herself with the warmth of it, lets it spread through her veins. When her eyes start closing, later, much later, she doesn't fight it.

She simply lets go, maybe for the first time in her life.

chapter 3

You're the reason that I feel so strong
The reason that I'm hanging on
You know you gave me all that time
Well, did I give enough of mine?

When she wakes up, Peter is not in the room. The bubble has bursted, and she expected that to happen, but she's disappointed nonetheless. Sighing, she pushes the blanket away and gets out of bed.

Grabbing shower essentials, she then leaves the room. But she doesn't get far undisturbed. The closer she gets to the kitchen, the more clearly she can hear voices.

Everyone's there.

She falters for a brief second, pausing, but then squares her shoulders and resumes walking.

Effort. She's making an effort.

As soon as she enters the kitchen, everyone's eyes land on her. Hers immediately find Peter's. He gives her a big, bright smile that soothes a spark of discomfort in her belly, and it gets easier to breathe.

"Gamora!"

Her gaze shifts to the person who spoke, to Calea, who immediately drops the knife on the counter and practically runs to Gamora. She comes to an abrupt stop the last possible second, right before their bodies touch, but even that sets Gamora on edge.

Calea is *very* close. Gamora *has* been close to people before—but that usually happened during fights. It's rarely initiated by someone. But it is. Now.

Calea wrinkles her nose, looking sheepish. "You probably don't want a hug, do you?"

Gamora's eyes dart to Peter. For reassurance. For an answer. He doesn't give it to her directly, but the sight of him makes her think of what he said just a few hours ago.

Because you matter, Gamora.

She doesn't believe him. She can't. But almost as if reading her mind, he gives her a nod, and she suddenly feels brave.

She looks back at Calea, trying to soften her features. "I'm not big fan of hugs." She also softens her voice. "If you're okay with that."

She doesn't remember the last time she spoke the truth instead of trying to hide.

Calea nods, unperturbed. “Of course!” Her smile falls off her face. “Are you okay? How are you feeling?”

Surprised by the question, that’s how. She swallows the disbelief. “I’m okay.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah.”

Calea’s face twists. “You saved my life. I… I don’t know how to thank you.” She looks guilty. Uncomfortable.

Gamora’s surprise grows. “It’s okay,” she reassures Calea. “You don’t need to thank me.”

“No, I do,” Calea frowns. “You could have *died*. I… I don’t know how you didn’t, but you could have, and I’m sorry. We shouldn’t have gone that far.”

Peter hasn’t told them. The thought is quick, it’s fleeting, but it renders her speechless for a moment. Calea doesn’t seem to know about the mods, and the gratitude prompts softness. It brings everything Gamora doesn’t know how to process closer to the surface.

She clears her throat. “You were doing your job, Calea. You needed those samples. I’m just glad you’re okay. That’s all that matters.”

Calea shakes her head. “We’re *both* okay. *That’*s what matters.”

Gamora’s throat tightens.

“But are you *really* okay?” Calea asks again.

She’s touched. She’s disturbed. Her fingers wrap around the towel in her hands. “I am.” She then thinks of something. “I guess you lost the samples? Do we need to go back?”

A smile is finally back on Calea’s face, making her look younger, more carefree. The smile turns into a pleased smirk, and she shakes her head. “Nope, we didn’t lose them. We don’t have much, but what we have is enough for a few experiments.”

“That’s great.” Gamora’s lips stretch in a small smile too. Mainly because they don’t have to repeat the mission. Or do they? “Will you… need more?”

“Hell no,” Calea scoffs. “I’m not going back there again. I’m going to dream of those teeth for the rest of my life.” She shudders a little.

Gamora wishes those teeth were the worst she’s seen. She doesn’t think she’ll ever dream of them. She has other things to keep her up at night.

Calea takes a step back, putting more distance between them. “We’re making dinner, would you like to join us after your shower?”

Gamora’s eyes widen. “Dinner?”

How long has she been asleep?

“You slept the entire day,” Peter finally joins the conversation.

She blinks at him, stunned. She isn’t sure what time she feel asleep, but she usually doesn’t sleep more than few hours at a time. How can it be dinner?

And how can she politely decline? She’s made an effort, and it was a good experience. She’s not ready for more, though. At all.

Her throat closes up. She remembers the way Calea’s face fell when Peter invited her to join them that one time. She doesn’t want to upset the girl now, not when her eyes are warm, welcoming, and soft.

“I…”

“Gamora has a ritual,” Peter says, making Calea look over her shoulder at him. “I mean, we all do, I guess,” he shrugs, and Gamora isn’t sure what he’s talking about. She looks at him in question. They all do. “But we have to take care of our weapons. It’s sort of a superstition.”

“A superstition?” Calea repeats.

“Yeah,” he nods. “We have to clean our weapon after fights. Take care of it, just like it takes care of us, you know? Gamora hasn’t clean her sword yet, and we all somehow think it’s a bad sign to let it sit dirty for long. She’d probably want to clean it before she does anything else.” He looks at her. “Right?”

How does he know what she needs? How does he lie on her behalf with such conviction? His voice is smooth, deep, and for a moment, she believes his made up superstition is real.

She wants to heave a sigh. His consideration pushes her closer and closer to a cliff she’s not ready to fall from. But she’s right there, right on the line. One more thing—and she *will* fall. Hard.

When Calea looks at her, she nods. “Peter is right. I have to clean my Godslayer first. Where is it?”

“We left it in the med bay,” he tells her. “But you could join us if you’re done quickly, right?”

And he does it again. Gives her exactly what she needs when he creates the illusion that she’s normal. That she won’t run away from a simple invitation. That her needing to be away is reasonable, and that the possibility of her joining is strong.

He closes the door—but he doesn’t shut it.

She operates in the absolutes. He’s so good at everything in between. She wants to know how he does it.

“Yes,” she nods.

“Okay, then,” Calea smiles. “I hope it doesn’t take you long.”

She stares at the girl. She sees no lie in her eyes. There’s no duplicity. There’s just eagerness and interest.

She’s never known that saving a lie could make someone like you—or whatever Calea is feeling toward her now. She stopped Thanos, in a way saving the universe, after all, and no one seemed to care about that.

How is this different?

She doesn’t know.

But she doesn’t have the heart to be curt with Calea. She doesn’t have the heart to shut the door. She doesn’t *want* to shut it. She gives her a smile. “I’ll do my best.”

***

She doesn’t join them for dinner, but she walks back into the kitchen when Calea finishes doing the dishes.

“Sorry,” Gamora says, holding up her Godslayer. “Their mucus was hard to remove.” It’s not even a lie.

“It’s okay. We left something for you.”

“You did?”

“Yeah,” Calea nods.

“Oh. Thank you.”

Calea turns water off. “No problem.” She wipes her hands. “I’ll see you tomorrow?”

“Yeah. Are you going out to get more samples?”

“Not tomorrow.” Calea leans against the counter. “We’re almost done here.” *Oh*. “But before we fly back to Xandar, I want to get couple more water samples. We’ll probably need few more days, but that’s all.”

Almost done. Few more days. That’s all.

They’ve been gone for couple weeks now, and it should be a lot. It *is* a lot. But at the same time, the news isn’t as good as she thought it once would be. Her chest feels tighter now.

Calea doesn’t notice. She smiles at Gamora and waves, gesture innocent, sweet. “Good night!”

“Good night,” Gamora echoes.

She suddenly regrets not joining them for dinner.

***

She prepares herself the entire night. Her heart beats so fast, she almost gets sick. Everything inside her feels heavy, and she changes her mind a hundred times.

But when the morning comes, she doesn't go straight to her bedroom. Instead, as she walks down the stairs, she looks at Peter who's already in the kitchen, pulling things out of the fridge.

"Hey," he greets her over his shoulder.

"Hey," she says back. "Is it… is it okay if I have breakfast with you guys?"

His heart skips a beat. She doesn't know if it's a happy skip or an annoyed skip.

He turns to face her, serious. His eyes scan her face, "It is okay if you want it."

Because you matter, Gamora.

Her throat has closed up, but she manages to get out. "I do."

His grin cracks his face in two. "Then it's more than okay."

Another skip—but this time, it's her heart. She's seen him happy before, she's seen him laugh, but his face has never lit up the way it does now.

She feels thrown off her axis, but she still sinks into the moment. She allows her body to respond to his happiness, and her stomach flips. It flips—and she feels like she's finally fallen over the edge.

Or maybe she's finally admitted that she fell a long, long time ago.

***

He finds her the night after.

It's deep into the night cycle, the night sky bright with stars and clear through the windshield of their ship, when she hears his footsteps on the deck below the cockpit.

Her heart flutters.

He climbs up stairs, and when his head is visible through the opening in the floor, she's already looking at him.

The lopsided smile he gives her is something she doesn't want to say goodbye to just in a few days. It brews fire in her chest.

"I can't sleep," he scrunches his nose.

He isn't asking a question, but he *is* asking a question. She's more than happy to give an answer. "Want to join me?"

He doesn't need any more prompting. He finish climbing the rest of stairs and then plops down in a seat on her left.

"I never thanked you," she says, almost too quietly, nervous all of a sudden.

"For what?"

"For giving me that excuse the other night. And for our conversation."

"You don't need to thank me for that."

Maybe not. But he's shown her kindness, and she wants to show it back. She rarely has a chance to do that. But she wants to. A lot.

"I still appreciate your help."

"I just wanted you to be comfortable," he says easily, leaning on his left elbow to and twisting his torso to be able to see her better. "I also liked learning things about you. I should be the one thanking you for that."

She doesn't follow. "Why?"

"Because you trusted me enough." They look at one another for a long moment. "It means a lot to me."

Her heart patters quickly. "You didn't tell them about my mods." *You didn't break my trust.*

"It wasn't my place to tell them that."

And now, I want to trust you with more. With everything.

*"*Thank you, Peter," she whispers quietly.

"Always." The words sounds like a promise. She wants it to be one.

He leans against the back of his seat, throwing his legs onto the panels in front of him. His head rolls to the side, his eyes finding hers. "Are you excited for the mission to end?"

No. She'd sleep on one of the bunks if it meant staying here just for a few more days. The truth sits heavy in her chest. "Are you?" She asks, instead of answering.

"No. I like this mission."

"Even though you mostly work alone?"

"Yeah," he nods.

"Can I ask you something?"

"Anything."

"*Why* do you work alone?"

He frowns. "Why not?"

Because you're you. Because people love you. Because you thrive in light and company and laughter. She doesn't say any of that. Instead, she shrugs a little, "You just seem to get along with people. So I was wondering."

"I do," he agrees. "But after living with the Ravagers, I value my own space a lot. And after Ego… after him wanting me to be something for him, I care about doing things that make *me* happy, not someone else. To work with someone… I just haven't met anyone who I'd want to compromise for."

Value my own space. And yet, he gave up his bedroom. For her. She doesn't know if she should comment on that or the end of his explanation. She drops her gaze, her tongue suddenly heavy. "But you agreed to this job."

A momentary silence. Then, "I did."

His tone is less benevolent now. It's not necessarily strained, but there's a ghost of something she can't identify. It makes her shift a little.

"Why?"

More silence. It lasts for a few seconds that seem like hours, and her body acts on its own when her head turns to her left. Their eyes meet, and she thinks she stop breathing. There's tenderness, there's nervousness floating in space between them, and his galloping heart matches hers.

Something blooms. She's not sure whether it's in her or between them, but she feels the impact of her gaze with every cell in her body.

"Because Nova Prime said she was going to ask you," he says eventually. "Your presence wasn't even guaranteed then, but I immediately said yes."

I've always wanted to work with you.

The breath gets stuck in her throat.

She made a fatal mistake of showing her interest to Nova Prime by not being able to mask her emotions when she should have. She also couldn't help a question about him once. For someone who never shows interest in something, she revealed her cards multiple times.

Nova Prime never commented, never brought it up until that day. *It's Peter Quill.* She'd known all along, but she used her knowledge only once. Even that was for Gamora's benefit.

She feels a sudden wave of gratitude.

Looking in Peter's eyes, she can't feel anything but.

“What if I’d said no?”

“Then I wouldn’t have come,” Peter says, “They would have had to find two other people.”

A simple answer. Like there was never any other option for him.

I want to keep this. The thought is terrifying. The depth of longing in it is one she’s never felt before. The intensity makes her speechless, and she doesn’t say anything for a few long moments.

Peter’s eyes fill with apprehension. “Too much truth?”

Yes. No. She doesn’t know. She exhales slowly, “A little bit.” When his face falls, she rushes to add, “Not because… not because I don’t want that truth. I’m just… I’m not used to this. To emotions. I’m alone most of the time.” *Socializing dazes me. In a very bad way.*

“You don’t deserve to be alone.”

I don’t want to be alone. She cannot say these words out loud. She cannot say many other words, mainly because she *feels* but doesn’t *know* what they mean—or how to explain them. But she can say something. “I wouldn’t have agreed to this job if it wasn’t for you.”

He’s surprised by her revelation. But a moment later, his eyes shine with hope. “Really?”

She nods. “I wanted to work with you too.” Heat creeps up her neck.

But maybe she can survive the burn. Maybe his contagious, warm happiness is worth it. A wide, goofy grin on his face makes her brave—or maybe stupid—and she feels her own lips stretch in a smile.

In a real smile.

Something bubbles up in her chest.

“Want to listen to something?” He asks her.

“Yes.”

“What are you in the mood for?”

And she finds herself giving the same answer—which is just as much truth now as it was that night. “Something happy.”

***

“We’ve grabbed everything we needed,” Calea announces the next day. “We will keep running tests in the lab on Xandar.”

Gamora knows what the words mean, but she still finds herself asking, “So there’s no need to stay on Galea anymore?”

“No,” Calea says. “We should return to Xandar.”

We should return to Xandar. Gamora nods, then says, “If you’ll excuse me.”

She turns around and leaves, struggling to catch her breath.

That night, she doesn’t have to keep watch. She still goes to the cockpit. Peter finds her there.

“I don’t want something happy tonight,” she mutters to him.

He plays sad songs.

***

“Thank you for your help.” Nova Prime looks at her and Peter. “We appreciate it.”

“No problem,” Peter smiles. “We were happy to do it.”

Nova Prime tilts her head to the side. She gives them both a long look, a spark of curiosity in her eyes. She doesn’t look like a commander now. She almost looks like a *friend.* One who *knows* something.

“I have no doubt about that.” Her lips curl upwards a little, and she sounds amused. “Does this mean that if we ever need two people on a job in the future, you two would be willing to work again?”

From the periphery of her vision, she sees Peter glance her way. He doesn’t say anything, and she realizes that it’s her call.

She gives Nova Prime a firm nod. “Yes.”

Nova Prime’s smile grows. Peter’s relief is almost palpable too.

“Well, then,” Nova Prime clicks her tongue, clasping her hands together. “That’s good to hear.”

When they leave Nova Prime’s office, Calea waits for them outside.

“Debrief went okay?” She asks them.

“Yeah,” Peter says easily, putting his jacket back on.

“Cool!” She says enthusiastically. “We’re going to celebrate our return, would you like to join us? It’s going to be a bunch of scientists from the lab and some officers too. I’m pretty sure Elora and Locke are gonna be there too.”

Gamora doesn’t know who Locke is. But she’s well aware of Elora. She thinks about that conversation, or the beginning of it, she witnessed between Peter and the girl.

Her spine involuntarily tenses.

“Yes, I’d love to,” Peter nods.

They both look at her. Calea’s eyes are full of excited expectation. Peter’s eyes are softer, full of understanding. She knows he knows it’s not her thing.

She hates public gatherings—at least, the idea of them, considering she never went to one before. The thought of being at a bar, or whatever that will be, surrounded by people who can’t stand her presence is enough to set her skin on fire.

But the thought of leaving Xandar—*Peter*—is equally nauseating. She thinks about turning around and walking away from the warmth—and her muscles tense.

Her body doesn’t want to walk away. So she blurts out, “I’ll be there.”

Calea smiles widely. “Cool!” She looks at Peter. “Usual place, usual time. See you there?”

He doesn’t look away from Gamora when he says, “Sure.”

Calea leaves them.

And it’s just the two of them.

“Are you sure?” He asks Gamora.

No, she isn’t. She’d rather do anything else than spend the night with people. But she thinks about thinking, *I want to keep this*, and realizes that desperation is stronger than fear. “No. But how bad can it be?”

Very bad. She pushes the thought away.

Peter nudges her shoulder. “It won’t be bad. I’ll be there.”

And that’s exactly why she’s going.

She knows hope has edges. She guesses she’s about to find out if desperation does too—and if those edges are sharp.

***

Before she enters the bar, she stands outside for a few long minutes, debating if she’s making a mistake. She probably is. She’s just trying to figure out if it’s worth it.

She *could* turn around and leave. She *could* go without saying goodbye. But she probably couldn’t silence the voice of longing.

What a stupid, impractical concept—to be sentimental. To be persuaded by feelings and hormones.

Thanos was convinced he taught her better—and once, she thought so too. But it's exactly that ugly truth, the realization that he would expect her to walk away from the bar, that finally pushes her to walk through the doors.

The music is loud, the sound ricocheting off the walls, and she winces immediately, her stomach pooling with anxiety. It gets worse when she's assaulted by different smells. And she feels even more out of place when she sees how many people there are in here.

It's a sensory overload.

Run. Run. Run.

She almost does, but she forces herself to look for Peter the last possible moment.

It doesn't take her long. She finds him near the bar, casually leaning against it. He's not alone. Of course he isn't. There'a a few people around them, and they all seem lost in a conversation. There's also a girl, a *pretty* girl. Her smile is the wildest, and Gamora watches her giggle.

Giggle. She doesn't think she ever made that sound in her life.

She watches them for a few long moments. She can't see Peter's expression, not with his back turned to her, but everyone, especially the girl, looks up at him like he's the sun. Which he is. But it's painful to realize she's not the only one thinking that.

Everyone wants to feel warm. He's exceptionally good at making that possible.

She turns on her heels.

"Gamora!"

Shit.

She looks over her shoulder, finding Calea standing just a feet away, a glass of something that reeks of alcohol in her hands. Her cheeks are flushed, her eyes are glinting, and she smiles widely. "You came!"

She shouldn't have done that.

Turning, Gamora shrugs a little. "Yeah."

"Let's go get you a drink!" This time, Calea has no reservations about physical contact, grabbing Gamora's arm without any regard. Gamora swallows back a hiss and an instinct to yank her arm away.

It's okay. It's okay. It's okay.

But it's *not*.

She doesn't know where Calea has found so much strength, but she only keep marching forward, dragging Gamora with her, despite swaying a little. Gamora has to lock her knees and wrap her own hand around Calea's elbow to stop them both.

At the questioning glance, she says, "I don't drink."

Calea wrinkles her nose in confusion. "At all?"

"At all."

"Oh." She finally lets go of Gamora's arm. "*Oh.* Okay. Would you like to grab some food then?"

"No, I'm good."

"Do you… do you dance?"

Dance? The question is so ridiculous she wants to scoff. Assassins don't dance. "No, I don't."

Calea's face falls. Gamora guesses this is the moment Calea goes back to not liking her. After all, what else is there to do?

She's not fun. She's not normal. She only makes everything awkward and tense, and she's a lot of work.

To her surprise, though, Calea's face grows sad, not irritated. "You hate being here, don't you?"

Gamora bites back a groan—she must look very uncomfortable for someone so drunk to be this insightful.

She can't find it in herself to lie. She also can't bring herself to admit the truth.

Calea takes a long sip from her glass. "Why did you come, then?" There's just plain curiosity in the question, no challenge. Possibly not realizing that, Calea rushes to add, "I'm not implying anything! I am just really curious."

Gamora *knows*. But she doesn't know why there's curiosity to begin with, so she asks, "Why are you curious?" She matches Calea's tone. No challenge. Just interest.

Calea hiccups, looking slightly disoriented for a moment. "I think I might be drunk." There's surprise in her voice. Almost like the admission is news to her? Gamora doesn't get it.

Calea pushes her blonde hair out of her face, and then, despite what she just said, takes another long sip. When she's done, her unfocused gaze meets Gamora's. "I'm curious because I like you and want to know more."

Dumbfounded, Gamora blinks. "What?"

“You saved my life,” Calea shrugs. “That’s one hell of a reason to like someone, I think. But I was curious even before that. You make a lot of people curious, you know that?” Without waiting for any answer, she adds, “You also make a lot of people angry.”

She hates the reminder. “I know.”

“And yet, you still came,” Calea mutters. “I mean, I’m happy you’re here. But… you’re not. So why?”

Gamora’s gaze involuntarily shifts to Peter. Mentally berating herself, she forces herself to look back at Calea. But it’s too late.

Calea’s face splits in an all-knowing grin. She chuckles, “So you’re just like the rest of us.”

Gamora furrows her brows. “What?”

In her state, Calea is surprised by Gamora’s confusion. She makes a face. “Well, you know…” Realizing that Gamora doesn’t know, she explains, “The whole I-want-to-be-where-the-guy-I-like-is kinda thing?”

“I don’t like him,” Gamora immediately denies.

Calea only snorts, “Sure.”

“I don’t,” Gamora insists.

“I’m drunk, but I have eyes.” Calea presses her lips together, trying to look stern. She doesn’t, but Gamora doesn’t think Calea realizes that. “At least you don’t have to worry if it’s reciprocated. So maybe you’re not exactly just like the rest of us.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

Calea rolls her eyes. “You look almost *too* oblivious.” At Gamora’s blank face, she instantly frowns. “Wait… you aren’t, are you?”

Gamora doesn’t say anything.

Calea whistles. “You *are*.” Her frown deepens. “His face lights up every time you walk into the room. You cannot be serious.”

“I think you’re drunk.”

“And I think you’re avoiding.”

“I better go.”

“What? No. Absolutely not.”

“I don’t think anyone is going to miss me.”

Calea rolls her eyes. “First of all, I want you to be here, so I will miss you.” Without missing a beat, she continues, “Plus he’s been waiting for you for an hour, looking at the door.”

“Well, he isn’t looking now, is he?” The truth is bitter on her tongue.

“Then make him look,” Calea shrugs, like her suggestion isn’t a big deal. Before Gamora can say anything, Calea turns her head and yells as loud as she can, “Quill!”

Gamora’s eyes widen. “What the hell are you doing?”

Calea only giggles. She even whoops when Peter looks in their direction, and Gamora isn’t sure how he even heard his name, but he did. As soon as his eyes land on Gamora, his beautiful, happy grin is all she can see.

She instantly struggles to catch her breath.

“See, I told you.” Calea sounds pleased.

Gamora pays her no mind. Her eyes are on Peter.

On how he instantly leaves the circle of people around him without even saying anything. He just sees her—and then he moves in her direction, worming through the bodies between them.

“You can thank me later,” Calea giggles. Gamora thinks she then leaves, but she’s not sure.

“You came,” Peter almost breathes out when he reaches her. “Hi.”

She doesn’t know why she suddenly wants to smile. She bites the inside of her cheek just to stop herself from doing that. “Hey.”

“Do you want a drink?”

She shakes her head. “I don’t drink.”

Peter nods, not asking any more questions. “Do you want to go out on the balcony? It’s quiet there.”

She’ll take quiet. She’ll take Peter’s undivided attention. “I’d love that.”

“Do you mind if I grab another bottle of beer before we go, though?”

“Not at all.”

He gives her a quick, grateful smile.

They start walking, and that’s when people start noticing her. They look at Peter—and then see her. She doesn’t hear any whispers, but she feels the surprise as if it was a palpable thing you could touch.

Her stomach clenches painfully. She doesn't want any attention. But it clings to her, latching itself onto her skin.

"Rich," Peter says once they reach the bar. "Can I grab another bottle, please?"

"Give me couple minutes," Rich nods, busy making another drink.

Peter looks at Gamora. "Would you like something?"

"No. I'm good."

She isn't. She feels everyone's eyes on her, and her shoulders stiffen even more. "A lot of people here tonight," she comments.

Peter looks at her a long moment. His face falls in understanding. "We can get out of here if you're uncomfortable."

"Aren't these your friends?"

"Some of them are. Most of them I met for the first time tonight," he shrugs.

"It's okay," she says. "We can stay."

She doesn't want him to leave anyone behind on her behalf. She doesn't want any whispers. He doesn't deserve that.

Even if a lump in her throat presses against it, making it hard to breathe. She shifts a little, trying to subtly shake her hands to get rid of the numbing tingling. It doesn't help.

She feels cold, despite the stifling heat in here.

She moves her fingers a little. They feel stiff.

She doesn't like what the signs mean.

"Where's the restroom?" She asks Peter.

He points behind himself, to the dark hallway.

She tries to give him a smile. "I'll be right back." She doesn't know if she succeeds.

She just needs a moment alone. She also needs cold water.

Numbness spreads through her body quickly. By the time she shuts the restroom door behind her, her vision is speckled with black dots. Leaning against the door, she closes her eyes, inhaling deeply. Exhaling slowly.

Her heart beats so fast she thinks it's about to jump out of her chest.

Even in here, she feels everyone's gazes.

Stupid. Stupid. Stupid. Why did she come?

Pushing away from the door, she walks over to the sink on shaky legs. Cold water doesn't help, no matter how much she splashes her face with it. Her skin burns, her chest rising and falling rapidly.

She can't be here. She just can't.

Her hands shake when she steps away from the sink. Looking at her reflection in the mirror, she chooses to stand still until the droplets of water dry off naturally. When they do, she squares her shoulders, takes a deep breath and leaves the washroom.

She almost rounds the corner leading up to the main section of the bar when loud voices, despite music, make her freeze.

"No, but what is she doing here?" She doesn't recognize the person speaking. "Who invited her?"

"Excuse me?" That's Calea. She sounds indignant, her voice raised. "What's your problem?"

"So *you* did," the first person scoffs. "What for?"

"You might want to be careful with your words." *Peter.* His voice is the opposite of Calea's. It's low, deadly. He sounds pissed.

"But why?" This time, it's someone else. New person. "Black Order is out there, isn't it? How can any of you trust her? She was his most loyal lackey. She *murdered* for him. Ruined *hundreds* of lives. Who's to say she's not playing a game? She might as well be the leader of the Black Order who's biding her time."

"Yeah?" Peter asks, his voice full of barely contained threat. "What else might she be, tell me?"

No. Please. Don't do this. Don't fight on my behalf. Her breath comes in a shallow burst. Almost a whimper.

I'm not worth it, Peter. Let it go.

He doesn't. "Whatever you think about her tells me about *you. Not* her. *Never* her. If you're a blind asshole, that's on *you*, but don't you dare accuse her of things she hasn't done."

"Hasn't done?" The guy chokes. "She mur—"

"In fact," Peter cuts him off. "Don't you dare speak about her at all. I guarantee you, you don't want to do that."

The guy only scoffs. Even from here, Gamora feels tension. Or maybe it's her own. She doesn't know. She's aware of very little. Only of how much her vision has started swimming —and how painful something broken in her chest feels.

“If you don’t want to be in the same room as her, then leave. If Gamora wants to stay, then she’s staying. It’s simple.” Calea doesn’t sound drunk anymore. She sounds angry.

Gamora feels hollow. Empty, empty, empty. Numb, too.

They shouldn’t be fighting for her.

A new voice joins the conversation. “As for your question about trust, I would advise you to think in the future.” That’s *Dey*. What is Dey doing here, of all people? “Nova Prime trusts Gamora. Are you questioning your commander?”

Silence. “No."

“And that was a lie,” Dey says. “To my face. To your superior, Laylie. You’re good at breaking unspoken rules, aren’t you?”

“I…” Nothing else comes out.

“We’re at a bar. Off work. I will not be holding this against you, but make no mistake, I will if you choose to cross the line again. Gamora’s life isn’t yours to scrutinize. So don’t.”

Her exhale is shaky. *Oh, Dey…*

“And *if* you choose to do it again,” Peter says—or threatens, really, “then you will be dealing with me. *Anyone* who does that will be dealing with me. Gamora’s a better person than any of you will ever be, and don’t *ever* forget that.”

Silence again.

“Anyone wants to say something else now?” Peter challenges them.

More silence.

“That’s what I thought.”

She presses her teeth into her lower lip, trying to silence herself. But another whimper, or something equally pathetic, escapes anyway. She slams a hand over her mouth.

What a mistake.

She should have said goodbye to Peter at the headquarters. If she were far away from Xandar now, none of this would be happening. They wouldn’t need to defend her. She wouldn’t be feeling like she’s bleeding out.

Desperation *does* have edges. And they’re sharp, *very* sharp.

She acted out of desperation—and now, she’s trapped in her pain.

Not worth it.

Not at all.

Her entire body shakes when she takes a step back. She cannot go out that way. She needs to find another exit. Now.

But it's hard to focus. Panic and pain make her sloppy, and her thoughts are slow, sluggish. She doesn't even hears Peter's footsteps until his face is suddenly in front of hers.

His expression is the mix of horror and desperation when he swear, "Shit."

She drops her gaze to the ground. She can't see concern. She doesn't want concern.

"Dammit," he swears again, his voice urgent and distressed. "I was hoping you were still in the washroom. I… Gamora…"

She doesn't say anything.

"Come on, let's get out of here."

She doesn't say anything.

"Gamora…"

She's frozen. And the shattered heart in her chest causes pain. It punctures every organ she can think of.

"I'm going to touch you, okay?"

She still doesn't say anything.

She's barely aware of him. The static noise in her head gets louder. The floor loses its colour. The more she stares at it, the more it resembles a black void.

Can it swallow her whole?

She feels fingers wrapping around her hand. Why?

She drags her gaze up. The green of her hand is dim, almost grey. The contrast between her and Peter's skin is wrong.

She shouldn't see any contrast. He shouldn't be touching her.

She tries to pull away.

He doesn't let her. Instead, he starts walking, tugging her hand. She doesn't think her legs will listen, but they do. She doesn't collapse. She might be almost out of it, everything around her blurry, bleak, but her body follows him.

She doesn't want that. She also does.

He makes her pain less acute. But his presence highlights everything there's wrong with her.

She wants him, and she wants to run away.

She hurts.

When they're outside, he stops them and turns to face her. "Tell me how to help you." He almost pleads. "What do you need?"

Many things. There's only one truth at the moment, though. "To not hurt."

chapter 4

Well, hold on, my darling
This mess was yours
Now your mess is mine

He takes her to his ship.

Once there, he lightly presses down on her shoulder, forcing her to sit down. Looking at her arms, he frowns. “Are you cold?”

She looks down. There’s shivers. Looking up, she shrugs.

“I’ll be right back.” He disappears down the hall.

When he’s back, he gently places a warm, soft blanket around her. “Here.”

Her heart patters a bit faster. But it’s still not enough to shake off the haze.

“I’m going to make you some hot chocolate, okay? Do you like it?”

She shrugs.

Peter’s sigh is heavy. “Gamora…”

She doesn’t say anything.

She murdered for him. Ruined hundreds of lives. Who’s to say she’s not playing a game?

He orphaned her. Imprisoned her. Turned her into his weapon. No one hates her more than him, and yet, her pain is not believable.

Because you matter, Gamora.

Does she?

Her eyes burn.

Her soul burns too. It’s frozen at the same time.

She doesn’t know how much time passes. She’s only focused on one thing.

She was his most loyal lackey.

She was his most loyal lackey.

She was his most loyal lackey.

Wasn't she? He ruined her to become the centre of her life. To become the only truth she ever believed in—that she was only ever good enough for him. That disobedience was punished. That nothing else mattered, only him.

He made her believe she was nothing—and now, everyone else reaffirms that.

And she's so tired. So very tired.

When Peter places a mug in front of her, she stares blankly at it, without reaching for it.

"Gamora…" His voice is full of pain.

The opposite of Thanos' voice. That voice was harsh and cruel. This voice isn't.

Peter places a plate next to the mug. When he gaze focuses on what's on the plate, she tries to blink the haze away. Or maybe it's only her tears she's trying to get rid of.

"You peeled a snazzberry for me." Her voice is hoarse.

"I did."

"Why?"

"Because you love it."

She looks up at him. "And that's a reason enough?"

"For me it is."

A simple truth. Her heart aches, her chest tightens.

What a futile attempt—to fight tears. They cloud her vision. The best she can do is hide them.

She drags her legs up, propping her heels on the edge of the seat, and then hides her face in her knees.

"I'm so sorry," Peter whispers, pained. "I'm so sorry you heard that. I'm so sorry they said those things. It's not true, okay? It's *not.*"

But it *is*. She *had* killed. She *had* ruined lives. She stopped him—but that doesn't magically change her past. The sins live under her skin, mixed with her blood. Her heart pumps the blood—and so it does pump the sins.

She wouldn't be alive without those.

"They're ignorant, privileged assholes. Don't listen to them."

"It's not just them," she mutters into her knees. "It's everyone. It doesn't matter where I am. Most of the time, when people recognize me, they react badly. He was right, after all. The Black Order is out there. Many think I'm biding my time."

“They’re ignorant assholes too. Everyone who thinks that is.”

“I don’t know about that,” she whispers. “They were hurt by me. They have the right to hate me.”

“And yet, it’s those who weren’t that complain the loudest. What right do they have? Being a Corpsman is often about status. It’s not about the goodness of their heart. They need to look in the mirror before they look at anyone else.”

Maybe Peter is right. But maybe, if they’re not good, they recognize the same thing in her. Or maybe they *are* good—and her darkness repels them. Either way, she’s doomed.

Her past drags her down. Lower and lower—until she can barely see the light. She hates the darkness. She wants the sunlight.

She turns her head a little to peek at Peter. His expression is torn, eyes angry. She doesn’t want him to be that, especially not on her behalf.

She likes it when he’s smiling.

“You shouldn’t have fought them.”

But he only presses his lips together. “Yes, I should have. I already told you that I was in your corner.”

She sighs, “Peter—”

“That means I will fight anyone,” he interrupts her. “Anytime.”

She wraps her arms around her legs. “What if it’s not worth it?”

“It *is* worth it. Because you are.”

Silence floats between them. She averts her gaze, whispering, “I’m not even normal.”

“Normal?” He sounds confused.

“Calea felt free and safe to get drunk, Peter. She never had to worry about control. None of them seem to worry about that,” Gamora says, her voice bitter. Jealous. “I’ve never even gotten drunk.”

He clears his throat. “Do you *want* to get drunk? I’m not sure I’m following.”

“It’s not about getting drunk,” she mutters, laying her cheek on her knee, returning her gaze to him. “It’s about them living these normal, mundane experiences, while I haven’t experienced most things.”

Peter leans forward, placing his elbows on the table. “No, you haven’t. Because you lived other experiences, Gamora. It doesn’t mean you’re not normal.”

“But it does,” she insists, trying to make him understand. “I don’t know most things that people seem to know. To *live*. Which makes it impossible to… be, I guess, around other people, even if they don’t seem to mind my company. I have nothing to contribute to any conversation.”

“Now that’s simply not true.” His brows dip in confusion. “You have a lot to contribute. I like our conversations the way they are.”

That’s different, she wants to say. Because *he* is different. He listens, he makes her feel seen in the best possible way, and he soothes her pain away. No one else has ever done that for her.

Then again, she never wanted other people to. She doesn’t think she ever will. She doesn’t want someone else’s warmth that way. She just wants his.

At least you don’t have to worry if it’s reciprocated. Is it?

“There’s beauty in your truth, Gamora,” he says. “It’s heartbreaking, the way you’ve accumulated that truth, and I wish you lived a different life, but to say you have nothing to contribute is wrong. You have so much to say. One just has to be willing to listen.”

Willing to listen. And he always has.

She’s dreading the day when he doesn’t. Just one thought about that—and she draws in a sharp breath.

“What?” He asks.

She only shakes her head, unwilling to be honest. Not this time.

He doesn’t push. “You’re *you*, Gamora. That’s the best thing you can be.” A small smile tips the right side of his mouth. “Who you are ain’t so bad, you know?”

She doesn’t know how he draws an almost amused snort out of her. “Not bad, huh?”

“I actually think you’re pretty great.” He winks, his tone light, but the sincerity in his gaze tells her he’s not joking.

He might be keeping everything light for her sake, but he means those words.

Her heart twitches in her chest. Happily, this time.

She doesn’t let her thoughts stray away to the words she heard before. She only focuses on Peter’s words now. Her body hungrily listens to them, needing relief that they bring.

“I don’t even know if I want to have many of those experiences,” she admits. “I don’t know if I’d want to be drunk. To let go of control like that… the idea is terrifying. But…” *I want to know what it’s like not to be worried. I want to know what it’s like to be free.*

They make it look so easy, so appealing—living that normal life full of normal, ordinary things. She wants to know what it's like. She wants to know if *that* makes them happy—or if they're happy because they're not broken.

"Don't do anything if you don't feel safe or comfortable," Peter shakes his head a little. "It's never worth it."

She doesn't tell him the only time she's ever felt safe was with him in the last two weeks. Especially after their conversation that night.

Exhaling, she shifts a little. "I just…" *I want to be more than who he tried to turn me into.*

But she doesn't know how to say those words. They get stuck in her mouth, sour and heavy on her tongue. Swallowing back a groan, she shifts a little, and her gaze falls to the mug and the plate in front of her.

The peeled fruit of snazzberry shines bright in the dark—metaphorically. He *peeled* it for her. She hadn't asked, and he still chose to do it.

Because you love it.

Her fingers twitch. She doesn't stop herself from reaching out and grabbing a slice. Sinking her teeth into the soft, sweet pulp, she sucks a little, drinking the juice.

When she's done, she looks at Peter. "Thank you." *For this. For everything*.

His smile is soft. "Always." He nods toward the drink. "Would you like to try hot chocolate too? My mom used to make it for me when I was sad. It always made me feel better almost instantly."

She doesn't think she needs the drink to feel better—Peter's presence works better than anything else. But she's intrigued by the comment about his mom.

Leaning forward, grabs the mug with both hands and brings it over to her chest, placing the drink on her knees. Sniffing it, she looks curiously at Peter. "What is it made of?"

"Chocolate powder, sugar and milk. It's better when you make it from scratch, but packets aren't bad either."

She takes a small sip. The drink is lukewarm, which she isn't a fan of, but the sweet taste makes up for the temperature. She makes a soft noise of surprise and takes a much bigger sip this time.

Peter's smile is broad. "Good?"

She doesn't fight her own smile. "Very." She chews on her lip for a second before she asks a question. "What else did your mom do to make you feel better?"

"We listened to music. And danced." His smile is now wistful, his voice melancholic. "She loved making music tapes for herself. We had so many tapes for different moods."

She isn't sure what a tape is. "Is… is your player a tape?" She definitely never saw anything like it before. It looks old, outdated.

Peter shakes his head. "My current player, the Zune, already had hundreds of downloaded songs when I got it. But before that, I had the Walkman. It didn't have any songs installed, you had to have an external carrier to be able to listen to music. It was my mom's, and it had just a few songs, but it was the most important thing I owned.

Owned. The past tense. Her voice is tentative when she asks, "What happened to it?"

A dark shadow falls over his face. "Ego crushed it. He… he smashed it with his fingers, and I have never felt so furious and hurt like in that moment. He'd killed her, and then he took the only thing I had left."

The anger she feels on his behalf takes her by surprise. But it's the pain she feels because he's hurting that reveals everything to her.

"I'm so sorry, Peter," she whispers.

"Yondu saved me that day. He flew the Milano to me just in time to drag us both out there. When he learned what Ego had done to the Walkman, he found the Zune for me. It's a present for him." Peter shrugs a little. "It's not my mom's, but it's pretty close."

She nods. She has many questions, but she doesn't want to overstep. To busy herself, she takes another sip.

Peter sits in silence for a moment. Then he shakes his head, almost as if trying to collect himself, and looks at her, his expression less haunted now. If anything, it resembles nervous excitement. "Are you… do you have any jobs coming up?"

"No. Why?"

He rolls his lips inside his mouth, sitting like that for a moment. "Would you be up for something?"

"Like what?" She doesn't know why she bothers to ask. She already knows what her answer is going to be.

"It's almost Christmas on Earth, you know?" She doesn't. She doesn't even know what Christmas is. "And Yondu and I… we've always given each other presents. I don't know where he is now, but I don't want to break the tradition."

She frowns. "Why don't you know where he is?"

"He was… exiled." Peter sighs, rubbing his forehead. "He was… favouring me, I guess. And that didn't sit right with the rest of the Ravagers. When he saved me from Ego, things only got worse. Right before that, he had… left someone from the clan behind. They died. But he chose to save me from Ego, and that was the last straw for them." Another dark shadow falls on his face. "They tried to kill him, and he barely escaped. I barely escaped too, I guess…"

That is news to Gamora. She never knew about that part of his life. “Since then, he’s been pretty much in hiding because he has no one left and they put a huge bounty out for him.”

“He doesn’t update you about his whereabouts?”

Peter snorts. “You haven’t met Yondu. Despite him saving me and being family, he isn’t exactly a warm, coddling type. He doesn’t see fit to update me. We don’t stay in touch except for very rare messages. I’m fine with that, but Christmas is couple weeks away, and I want to see him.”

She nods slowly.

He loves Yondu—she can see that.

She doesn’t really understand how he can—Yondu *kidnapped* him. But maybe having a kidnapper who isn’t an ego-centrical, power obsessed maniac leaves room for warm feelings.

Maybe… maybe being saved helps too. Gods know Calea changed her mind because of that too.

And still—she isn’t a fan of Yondu.

But she’s a fan of Peter—and the thought is embarrassing, even if it’s still true. So she nods, “Okay.”

He blinks. “Okay?”

“Did you expect me to say no?”

“Well, no… but… Really?”

“Yes, Peter. Really.”

He grins, and it’s a pure, open delight that touches her in places she never expected. But then something occurs to him, and he frowns a little. “It might take a while. And I don’t have a room here.” He looks almost apologetic. “Unless… we could take your ship if you’d like?”

“Do you… do you have bunks?”

“I do, but… would you be okay with those?”

I trust you. I want you. It’s hard to put the truth back in the box once it’s out. She sighs, feeling defeated. “Yes.” She thinks of something. “It’s going to be just… us?”

Us. Two weeks ago, there were no *us*.

Peter nods. “Just us.”

And now, she’s a part of a something bigger.

“Then I’m okay with bunks. They have protective shields, right?”

“Of course.”

“Okay, then. I’m in.”

She sees how much he wants to get excited, his eyes shining brighter than a moment before. He restrains himself, though. “Are you sure? I don’t want you to feel obligated.”

There’s many things she could say. A simple, *Yes, I’m sure,* would be sufficient. *I’ve already agreed, haven’t I?* would be a great answer too.

Instead, she chooses to blurt out the truth, “I like your company, and I don’t want to be alone.”

Her ears instantly burn. Closing her eyes, embarrassed, she wills her heart to slow down, but it only keeps racing.

“I like your company too, Gamora, and I wouldn’t want to do this with anyone else.”

She can’t remember the last time she was so startled. Peeling her eyes open, she looks at him, dazed and… something else too. Warm? Nervous? Excited? All at once, maybe?

Her stomach feels very… weird.

She presses a hand against it.

“Really?” Her voice sounds oddly choked.

“Really.”

To work with someone… I just haven’t met anyone who I’d want to compromise for.

The feeling in her belly intensifies. The hoarseness in her voice intensifies too when she whispers, “Okay.”

This time, he lets himself grin. And she can’t be unaffected. Her own lips stretch in a smile, and then she hides behind the mug, taking another sip.

“After we parted ways today, I restocked my fridge, so there’s enough food here. Do you need to grab anything from your ship?”

Her holo is there. Her clothes too. Her toiletries. “Yes.”

“Do you want to go grab it now?”

“When do we have to leave?”

“There’s no deadline. We can do it wherever we want.”

We. She’s a part of a *we*. Hope lights every nerve ending she has.

“I’ll grab it later, okay? And we can leave in the morning?”

Peter nods easily. “Okay. What do you want to do now?”

To live. She’s not surprised by the longing. But she’s surprised by her eagerness. Maybe she shouldn’t be.

You have so much to say. One just has to be willing to listen.

He’s been listening to her for a while. Right now, she wants nothing more than to listen to *him*. “Play me some of your favourite songs?”

He does.

chapter 5

She adjusts—and she does that easily. She expected the desire to be in Peter's presence be greater than fear, but she never expected the fear to be gone completely. But it is.

Somehow, they make it work—and she doesn't even have to try. It just happens. Naturally.

He makes it easy.

In the span of few days—few weeks, maybe, because the mission changed everything too—she's gone from never talking to another being to talking to someone all the time. As it turns out, it's not as dreadful.

She almost doesn't wait for the other shoe to drop. She almost believes that lightness is here to stay.

***

He looks tired, sleepily rubbing his eyes. The blanket pools around his waist, revealing him dressed into a t-shirt, and she looks away, biting her lip. The lack of visuals doesn't help, though—she's already memorized the bulging of his muscles.

Moments like this she regrets choosing a bunk across his. Moments like this is also the reason why she chose a bunk across his—and that is a secret she's unwilling to admit even to herself.

Her cheeks burn a little.

She drags her blanket higher, clutching it tightly in her fingers and half-hiding her face behind it. She knows his vision is inferior to hers, but she's terrified he might see the dark green.

Until him, she didn't even know she could blush.

But she can. And she does. A lot.

He rolls over to his side, his eyes now on her.

Before he can say anything, she says quietly, "I'm sorry this planet was another dead end."

Her shrugs a little. "It's okay. We can always try tomorrow."

He's said these words every time, trying to remain optimistic, but she sees how exhausting and draining it is for him. They've visited four planets where Yondu could have been, and each and every trip was useless.

She's frustrated with Yondu. If he answered one of *many* messages Peter sent him, none of this would be happening. How selfish one must be? She knows all about having to lay low

and be in hiding—but she also knows she would never let Peter suffer.

Yondu, apparently, has no problem with that.

She lets out a sigh. Then tries to give Peter a reassuring smile. “We will.”

He props his head on his palm, looking at her with a ghost of concern. “You… you don’t want to go back just yet?”

She hates the insecurity and the doubt in his voice. “No, I don’t.”

“Are you sure? ‘Cause we’ve been doing this for over a week now, so if you wanted to go back… I—“

“Peter.”

“Yeah?”

“I don’t want to go back.” She’s dreading the moment they find Yondu, actually. She also wants it more than anything, for Peter’s sake. “I’m okay right here.”

His eyes crinkle when he smiles. “Okay.”

She shifts a little, dragging her knees closer to her chest. “Music now?”

His smile widens. “Music now.”

He drops his arm to the floor, blindly reaching for his Zune, and she settles in even more comfortably.

This has become a tradition—listening to music before they both fall asleep. Sometimes they talk a lot. Sometimes it’s just a quick chat, like today. But there’s always music.

“What are you in the mood for?”

She thinks about it for a moment. “I don’t know. Surprise me?”

He looks excited at the prospect. “Sure thing.”

When the melody starts a few minutes later, Gamora doesn’t recognize it. She loves how even after all this time, there’s still new songs to discover.

She quickly reaches for the remote control and dims the main light source, letting only one lamp illuminate the sleeping area. Falling back onto her side, she stares at Peter, soaking up the lyrics.

I need to tell you
How you light up every second of the day

He stares right back at her, holding her gaze.

But in the moonlight
You just shine like a beacon on the bay

His excited smile disappears. Instead, she sees something resembling fondness. With a sudden lump in her throat, she feels like her head spins a little.

And I can't explain
But it's something about the way you look tonight
Takes my breath away

"That's, uh… this song is…" She doesn't know what she's trying to say.

It's that feeling I get about you, deep inside
And I can't describe

"I feel that I can… relate to it a lot," Peter admits.

She bites her lip. *At least you don't have to worry if it's reciprocated.*

Her voice shakes when she asks, "You do?"

With your smile
You pull the deepest secrets from my heart

He hesitates at first. "Does that… bother you?"

In all honesty
I'm speechless and I don't know where to start

She takes even longer to reply. Her voice is muffled behind the blanket and her palm. "No."

"No?"

"No." Her whisper is barely audible. "I like it." She's terrified, she's afraid of his honesty, of her reaction to it, but she *likes* it.

He replies by grinning. It's that wide, happy, genuine grin that she loves almost more than anything.

The automatic way her lips stretch, prompted by his own smile, the way relief is almost a physical, tangible thing in her chest—she's already familiar with the symptoms. Just one look at happy Peter—and her poor, fractured heart doesn't feel fractured anymore.

She's *caused* his happiness. It's empowering—to know she's the reason. And unbelievable. It's also something she doesn't want to change, ever.

"I'm glad," he mutters.

She is too.

“Night, Gamora,” he whispers.

“Night, Peter.”

Neither of them raises the privacy shield. She might have asked if there was one, but she hasn’t used it a single time. He hasn’t either.

***

She’s almost done with her workout when Peter enters the gym nook. *Shirtless.*

She swallows her surprise—and whatever else she doesn’t want to name—and turns around, pretending she hasn’t noticed anything.

Her heart is beating rapidly in her chest though.

Breathe. Breathe. Breathe. It’s just a body. But her brain refuses to listen to her, saying that it isn’t just a body. It’s *Peter’s*. She never thought she was shallow, but…

She fights the shivers.

When she stands up, abandoning the last part of her workout—stretching—Peter just gives her a quizzical look. “Where are you going?”

“Oh… I’m… you know…” she points somewhere to the side, instantly frustrated with herself for stammering. “I’m… uh, done.”

“Oh?”

She doesn’t think he believes her. She doesn’t believe herself. She still chooses to lie. “Well, yeah… I… I’m gonna go.”

She moves past him, holding her breath when as she goes, trying to minimize the influence he has on her body. It doesn’t help. His scent invades her nostrils, the sight of his chest is burned on the inside of her lids, and she feels her belly flip.

Stop this.

But it doesn’t work.

***

He finds her a while later in the cockpit. When she looks at him over his shoulder, finding him dressed in his normal long sleeve, he looks regretful. “Did I make you uncomfortable?”

“No.”

He didn’t. Her own reaction to him did.

She’s glad he’s dressed now. She’s disappointed—and angry with herself for that.

“I’m sorry, I should have—“

“It’s fine, Peter.” She gives him an empty smile. She needs him to stop talking about it. “I was done with my workout anyway, and I needed to check my holo.”

He tilts his head. “Oh. Have you… heard from Nebula?”

She only lets out a long, tired sigh. All of her messages are still unanswered. Sometimes, she thinks Nebula and Yondu need to become friends only if to compare notes on how to ignore people who are trying to find them.

Peter walks over and drops into his seat. “I’m sorry.”

She’s sorry too. “Maybe I should give up the idea of trying to find her. She’s making it obvious she doesn’t want to do anything with me.” Gamora scoffs then, “I mean… why would she?”

Peter instantly frowns. “Don’t say that.”

“It’s true,” she shrugs a little. “She was hurt because of me. I understand why she hates me.”

“You two were kids. You were trying to survive.”

You were the one who wanted to win. I just wanted a sister. Those words were the last words she heard from Nebula after they defeated Thanos. She hasn’t stopped thinking about them even for a moment.

She sighs again.

“Would you like us to go look for her?”

She instantly turns her head to look at Peter. “What?”

“I know you’re texting her, but what if we… try to go look for her? Like, actually look for her? You mentioned you have some of your contacts, and she must be out there, right? How hard can it be?”

Gamora only blinks at him.

He shrugs. “Just one words, and we can leave for the new mission right away.”

The new mission. She shakes her head. “We’re looking for Yondu.”

Peter just waves her off. “We can look for him later. He’s not exactly interested in being found, is he?”

No, he isn’t. Gamora presses her lips together. Peter deserves better. And yet, he only wants one thing.

“We’re not going on a new mission,” she says, her voice leaving no room for argument. “We’re going to keep looking for Yondu until we find him.”

A dark shadow passes across Peter’s face. “What if it takes forever?”

“Then it takes forever.” She sure as hell hopes it won’t. He still looks doubtful, so she shakes her head a little. “I’m… I’m in your corner too.” She feels her cheeks heat. “If you want to keep searching for him, then I’m right with you. It doesn’t matter how long it takes.”

The truth—this uncharacteristic level of straightforwardness—should be terrifying, and it *is*, but it also leaves her feeling great. She likes how a few simple, honest words erase the dark storm from Peter’s eyes.

She likes it when he looks less haunted.

The corners of his mouth lift up in a playful smirk. “In my corner, huh?”

She’s never said that to him before. She guesses the teasing is warranted. She still rolls her eyes, scoffing quietly.

He chuckles. But then grows serious. “I know.” His tone is soft, full of appreciation. “I know you’re in my corner. Thank you, Gamora.”

Always. She doesn’t say the word, but she hopes Peter can hear it.

“I cannot express how much your trust means to me,” he continues, voice even softer now. “You telling me about looking for Nebula was…” he trails off a little. “I just… Thank you for trusting me with that. And I know how important it is to you. So if you want to go actually look for her, I will help. If you need my help, that is,” he adds.

He makes her feel vulnerable. He makes her feel exposed. But above all, he makes her feel seen. The heartache is sweet this time. “Thank you,” she whispers, choking on all the feelings she never thought she could have.

“Always.”

He hears what she doesn’t say—and then he’s brave enough to voice it.

***

She might be unable to voice things, but she knows how to act. The feelings that flood her chest make her dizzy, but she’s done being a bystander. Not anymore.

When Peter is distracted with making dinner—because she’s completely useless in the kitchen, and he’s slightly better—she escapes to the lower level, trying to get as far away from him as possible.

When she feels like there’s a good amount of distance, she dials Dey’s code.

He picks up on the third ring.

“Gamora?”

“Hey, Dey,” she greets him. “How’s everything?”

“Uh… good?” He frowns at her. “Is everything okay?”

She’s never called him before, so she understands his reaction. But she’s never felt like her happiness depended on someone else’s happiness either, so there’s first time for everything.

She folds her arms on her chest. “Can you please do something for me?”

Dey tilts his head. “Like what?”

“Can you help me track down a Ravager?” She raises her chin up a little. “That Ravager cannot be arrested though. No matter what record you have on him.”

“Um…”

“Please, Dey.” She holds his gaze, not hiding the urgency she feels. “Whatever you want me to do, I will. If the Nova Corps needs me to work for free, I will. If you need me to owe you a million deals, I will. Absolutely anything you can come up with, I will do it. I just… I need to find him.”

Dey stays silent for a few long moments. Then he exhales loudly and rubs his neck. “Who’s the Ravager?”

“Yondu Udonta.”

The realization hits Dey. He raises his eyebrows in a silent question. “Peter Quill’s Yondu Udonta?”

She doesn’t give him what he wants to hear. She simply nods. “Yes, that Yondu.”

Dey rubs his neck again, looking torn. “He has a pretty long record.”

He could be Thanos himself—and she would still try to find him for Peter. He’s owed at least this much relief in his life.

“Please,” she begs again. “I just need to know where he is. We cannot track him using the standard software. If you could just… point me in the right direction.”

Dey heaves a sigh. “You’re asking for a lot.”

“It’s important.”

She clutches at her chest, right where her heart reacts to what she’s saying—and everything that she isn’t. Because it’s not *‘it’* that’s important. It’s *‘him’*.

Silence lasts for a few long beats.

“Dammit… Okay,” Dey nods, looking defeated. “He hasn’t been on our radar in a long time, so I cannot guarantee I will find his whereabouts, but I will see what I can do.”

She closes her eyes in relief for a second. “Thank you, Dey.”

“I hope it’s worth it.”

He is.

***

She loves looking at Peter right before they’re about to fall asleep.

This level of intimacy makes her heart yearn for more, and the space between them—between their bunks—gets irritating. It doesn’t feel protective anymore. Only restrictive.

“Why do you like Christmas so much?” She whispers, wanting to know more.

His smile is wistful. “We never really had a lot of money, and when mom got sick, things got even worse. But Christmas, and the whole month of December, I guess, was just…” he shrugs a little. “We decorated the house, and it looked… magical. I loved the lights so much. I loved seeing tiny figurines of Santa and Rudolph and snowman.” She has no idea who any of these people are, but she doesn’t ask. “Everything looked like it was from a fairytale, and I always believed a miracle was just around the corner, you know?”

She does now. She *knows* now. Because the moment he entered her life, she started believing a miracle wasn’t too far, wasn’t too impossible to grasp. A concept once wild feels natural now.

So she nods.

“Mom worked a lot, but in December, we would do everything together. We would bake cookies, and we would decorate the tree, and we would make snow angels. Every day, there was something to do, and I just felt… so close to her, I guess?” His smile is sad, melancholic. “It was a month full of happiness and love. Christmas was also my mom’s favourite holiday too.”

“That sounds lovely.”

“It was. I haven’t done most of those activities since I left Earth, but I tried to celebrate in my own way. That’s why it’s important for me to find Yondu. I just… I don’t want the tradition to end. Not when it’s sort of a bridge, or connection, maybe, to my mom. I want to honour her memory. Not celebrating Christmas… it just feels like letting her down and forgetting about her.”

She will go to the end of the universe if she has to find Yondu. Peter *will* see him, and he will see him soon. She will make sure of it.

“We will find him,” she makes a promise. “When is Christmas?”

“A few days away.”

Not ideal, but she still has time.

“We will find him, Peter,” she repeats. “I promise you.”

***

They land on Knowhere the next day. This time, a quick stop isn’t because of Yondu but out of necessity to get more food and fuel for the Milano.

Gamora tries to swallow down her apprehension. Knowhere has always been a spot for her to see her contacts when she was working for Thanos, so none of the memories are pleasant.

Peter must notice her expression. “You okay?”

She wrinkles her nose. “I don’t like this planet.”

“We can leave.”

She shakes her head. “No. We’re already here. I’m fine.”

He gives her a long look full of concern, and she tries to give him a smile in return. “I’m okay. Let’s just grab some food, okay?”

Before he can answer, someone bumps into her, and the force of the collision is enough to make her stumble for a second. Peter immediately steps closer to her, his hand flying to her lower back to stabilize her.

Even through the jacket, she feels his touch.

He looks at whoever bumped into her over his shoulder. “Asshole,” he mutters, his eyes narrowed. He then looks back at her. “Are you okay?”

No. Her entire body is on fire. His hand is big, it’s warm, and she thinks embarrassing thoughts. Shaking her head to clear her mind of nonsense, she says, “All good. Good to know Knowhere hasn’t changed much.”

They enter the food market, the yelling and the beeping and all the other sounds and smells of this planet assaulting her senses for a brief moment. That—or it’s Peter’s hand that messes up with her ability to process what’s happening.

He still hasn’t stepped away. The heat of his body seeps into hers, and wherever she moves, her side and her left arm brush against his chest. Has the market always been so stifling hot?

She adjusts the collar of her shirt. It doesn’t help.

“Do you want to split up?” He asks.

That would be a sensible thing to do. They could cover more ground, be done faster. Instead, she shakes her head. “No.”

He finally steps away—but he doesn’t go far, watching her and everyone around them like a hawk. Every single time someone gets too close to her, especially if they look like they’re in a rush, Peter steps closer, his hand flying to her elbow. He doesn’t touch her again, but he looks like he will if someone collides with her again.

It’s maddening how stupidly affected she is because of the gesture.

She’s an assassin. She used to be Thanos’ lackey. She knows how to fight. And yet, knowing that Peter is right there to catch her if needed makes the heat in her stomach burn stronger and faster.

When they stop in front of a vendor that sells lots of fruits, Peter’s eyes light up. He turns to her, practically vibrating with excitement. “Have you tried this before?” He points to an orange fruit, shaped like a rectangle.

“No. What’s that?” She looks at the tag. Madu doesn’t mean much to her. She’s never heard the name before.

“It’s actually relatively similar to snazzberries, so I think you’d like it. It’s sweet and,” he gives her a knowing look, smirking, “much easier to peel. Then again, you wouldn’t know anything about peeling, would you?”

She rolls her eyes. He’s made fun of her for not wanting to buy fruits of snazzberry because she refuses to peel it too many times in the last few weeks. Every single time, he would still get it for her—and then peel it when they back to the Milano.

She’s never felt more cared for.

“Well, you were the one who said you didn’t mind peeling,” she shrugs. “So you only have to blame yourself.”

“Wow,” he laughs. “No good deed goes unpunished.”

“You had to learn that at some point, so you’re welcome.”

“Ouch.”

She grins at him.

He grins back.

She thinks, for the millionth time, how much she doesn’t want to leave after they find Yondu.

Peter looks at the vendor. “Can we please have a bag of madu?” He looks at her from his peripheral vision. “And snazzberries too, please.”

Her heart melts a little. “You really don’t have to.”

“I want to.”

She hides her stupid, wide smile behind her hand.

They stop at a couple more booths, buying the rest of stuff they normally eat, and when they leave the market, the streets outside seem even more alive than they were half an hour before.

“Oh, wait,” Peter says, his eyes trained on a store on the opposite side of the street. “I want to get a new shirt. Do you mind waiting for me?”

“Go ahead. Let me grab the basket.”

“I’ll be really quick, okay?”

She steps to the side, trying to get out of everyone’s way as much as possible. With Peter gone, her apprehension returns, and she looks around, vigilant. The need to assess all the possible threats is a purely automatic reaction.

Pressing her back against the stone wall, she tries to take a deep breath. But it’s easier to fight the old memories when she’s creating the new ones with Peter.

She tries not to think about how dependant on him she’s become.

A sudden yelp, followed by a shriek and then laughter, drags her attention to the left. Her gaze focuses on a bar and a couple that just stumbled out of it. The girl looks like she’s a mess—and the kind of mess that Gamora never got to be.

The girl grips the guy’s hand, trying to stay upright, and she looks at him with such adoration that Gamora feels uncomfortable for a moment. The girl’s eyes are hooded, they’re completely unfocused, and she can barely stand, but she looks at the guy by her side like he’s the sun.

She sways a little, her knees buckling, and the guy instantly wraps his hand around her waist. The girl giggles, carefree. She throws her arms around the guy’s neck and raises on her tiptoes.

When they kiss, Gamora blink at them.

When the kiss lasts, with the girl pressing her entire body against the guy’s, her hands gripping the guy’s locks and angling his head, Gamora looks away.

Her cheeks burn.

She’s familiar with jealousy and longing, but being familiar doesn’t make it easier to feel the emotions. Her stomach churns a little.

She's been hidden in a bubble inside the Milano, deceived by the normalcy of the shared solitude, but the real world hasn't changed.

She hasn't either.

Not normal. Not normal. Not normal. People out there—out *here*—live their lives, unafraid to lose control in the shadiest of places, free to kiss their lovers. She feels a rise of panic, tightly intertwined with desire, when she lets herself wonder what it would be like to kiss Peter.

Her body wants to. Her *heart* wants to. Her mind freezes, though. Every single time.

She heaves a sigh, closing her eyes for a few long moments, trying to compose herself. She has to count to twenty before her heartbeat slows down at least a little bit.

"Hey, you okay?"

She peels her eyes open, finding Peter in front of her. "Oh, yeah, I am. Sorry. I didn't realize you were done. Did you find anything?"

He probably sees through her poor attempt to redirect the conversation, but he doesn't call her out on it. "No, no luck this time. Ready to go back to the Milano?"

She gives him a nod, now more eager to get off the planet than even a few minutes ago.

***

Dey. Any updates?

No, not yet.

I'm so sorry to rush you, but it's kind of time-sensitive. I only have couple more days.

I will do my best.

***

Dey?

Nothing.

She groans in frustration.

***

"Wow," Peter whistles. "I forgot that I had this."

He's looking inside an open cupboard, his back is to her. She cannot see what he's talking about, so she tries to lean to the side. When it doesn't work, she asks, "What is it?"

He turns to her, lifting up a bottle of something, looking excited. “Asgardian liquor. Some really good stuff.”

Her brain processes the meaning and supplies one word. *Alcohol*. A moment later it supplies another word, a much more important one. *Strong* alcohol. The kind her body would potentially find challenging.

She sits a little bit straighter, licking her lips, unsure.

The memory of the drunk, happy girl invades her mind. So does the memory of Calea at the bar. The memory of Peter’s words follows. *Don’t do anything if you don’t feel safe or comfortable.*

She *is* safe, she *is* comfortable—but only with him. She doesn’t think she will ever have that anywhere else. She mulls over this for a few log moments and then blurts out, “I want to try it.”

Peter blinks at her. “What?”

“I want to try the liquor.”

She doesn’t know what exactly she’s saying, but she doesn’t care. Thanos resented alcohol, found it useless, *an escape of the weak*. The idea of losing control terrifies her almost more than anything else, but the idea of going against him, even in something so painfully foolish, makes her heart beat faster.

Peter has given her so many new experiences. Why not one more?

She shifts on the chair, nervous and hopeful at the same time. How bad can it be?

She ignores the part of her brain that says, *Very*. She survived going to the bar. She’d survived much, much worse.

This time, she won’t have to do it alone. The simple remainder is enough to make her nod to herself. “I want to try,” she repeats again.

“Uh… you do?”

“Yes.”

Peter looks at her a few long moments, scanning her face, his eyes narrowed. She fiddles with a loose thread on her pants without looking down, not willing to betray her apprehension. She’s lucky her hand is hidden by the table—otherwise he would see the nervous tick, she’s sure.

But he’s clueless.

Or maybe he’s not. Maybe he knows her well enough because he asks, his voice serious, “Are you *sure?”*

“Yes.” Is she? She is. She *must be*. How long can she be running away from a threat that doesn’t even exist anymore? Her voice shakes a little nonetheless.

Peter only exhales. He bites the inside of his cheek, looking less than enthusiastic about the idea. And she drops her gaze to her lap.

Sometimes silence is louder than words. She knows everything that Peter isn’t saying, his silence expressing concern, confusion and a soft refusal all at once. For once, she believes he’s thinking about her. For once, she softly admits a simplified version of her truth. “You told me to drink when I feel safe. Well, I feel safe. With you.”

His heart comes to a stop, then restarts. Her own heartbeat matches his.

Self-conscious about being so straightforward, she digs her nails into her thigh.

This time, silence doesn’t speak louder than words. She doesn’t know what it means.

“Gamora.” There’s almost a plea in Peter’s voice.

She looks up. His eyes are drown in hesitation and something else. He leaves the bottle on the counter and slowly comes closer to her. When he sits on the chair opposite her, there’s just a few inches between their knees. She stares at the distance for a few moments, mesmerized, until he speaks.

“Why do you want to get drunk? You said you weren’t even sure if you wanted to try it.”

His voice is quiet, soft. It pulls at something in her chest, and she finds herself unable to lie.

“I want to erase Thanos’ voice from my mind. I want to prove him wrong. I want to see what the fuss is about.” *I want to be able to think about a kiss without freaking out.*

He looks sad. “Those aren’t happy, good reasons.”

She almost snorts, unamused. “I don’t have any of those.” She bites her lip, falling silent for a moment, and then whispers, “I trust you, Peter. Ever since we met, I’ve tried many things, and that wasn’t as scary as I’d thought. I want to do something I’m terrified of.”

“I hate that he ruined you life and he *still* keeps haunting you.” Peter’s eyes flash with anger. They always do when Thanos is mentioned. “You should do what you want, not what he’s making you do.”

She cannot ever imagine living that life, but the idea is so nice she almost smiles. The scars are too deep, however. She’s afraid Thanos broke her beyond repair. Then again, her sitting here and *talking* about this is proof that maybe he didn’t.

She drops her gaze to where her knee almost touches Peter’s. “I can’t know what I want if I don’t know if I like it. That’s why I want to try. If I hate it, which I suspect I might, then I’ll at least know I tried.”

Peter doesn't say anything for a minute. The silence isn't necessarily heavy, but it's full of longing and regret. Eventually, he lets out a sigh and bumps her knee with his.

She slowly looks up.

"Okay," he says. "But we gotta do it my way."

"Your way?" She frowns.

He nods. "Drinking your pain away isn't fun, I've tried and it doesn't work. We have to find good reasons to drink, *happy ones."*

*"*I don't have those," she reminds him.

He narrows his eyes at her. "Now that's simply not true. You do. *We* do."

"We do?"

"Of course! We had a great today today." He holds up one finger. At her confused glance, he clarifies, "No one got hurt, no one got injured, that counts. Christmas is couple days away, so that's another great reason." His nose wrinkles, and she finds it almost adorable. "Although, that probably isn't a strong enough reason for you. But still, I'm keeping it." He holds up the second finger. Then he grins. "We get to hang out. I don't know about you, but that is definitely good enough for me." He holds up two more fingers.

"*Two* more?" She asks, fighting her sudden smile.

He winks and holds up the last, fifth finger. "Three, actually. Hanging out is the greatest reason of all." Then he tilts his head to the side, feigning offence. "What? You don't agree?"

She doesn't know how he does it, but she cracks a smile. "I do, I do," she laughs lightly. A moment later she asks, "That's really enough for you to be happy? You listed pretty… mundane, small things."

He shrugs. "It's those moments that make life good. There's so much bad out there, and I have to find joy in simple things. Otherwise, there's nothing worth living for. Big moments are rare, you know?"

Her smile gets almost wistful, her chest filling with something resembling awe. He really is *good*. Warm, bright, and so full of life.

She understands why the darkness inside her reaches for his light.

"I need to celebrate small victories rather than foster my pain," he shrugs a little. "So when we drink, let's focus on the good stuff, okay? He's not worth your time to drown your pain."

He isn't worth that, is he?

She *trusts* Peter, she *believes* Peter—so she chooses to believe him now too. "Okay."

His smile is bright. “Great.” He stands up and offers her his hand.

She takes it without hesitation and instantly shivers. The direct contact of skin against skin is rare, and she instantly gets flustered. Once she’s upright and he pulls his hand away, she immediately misses the touch.

“You know what makes everything even better?” He asks her.

She knows what answer he’s looking for, so she humours him. “Music, of course.”

“Exactly!” He beams at her. “I haven’t played you Christmas songs yet. We have to fix that tonight.”

He might want to fix that one thing, but in reality, he’s fixing so much more.

***

The smell is almost repulsive. The taste isn’t much better. The liquid burns her throat a little, and she wrinkles her nose.

“So… not good?” Peter laughs.

She makes a face.

He snorts. “It’s actually pretty good. Well, in comparison,” he amends. “Definitely don’t go drinking cheap stuff at bars then.”

She doesn’t think she’ll ever would want to enter a bar ever again, but she doesn’t bring up that night. Instead, she grabs a piece of madu to taste something other than bitter taste of liquor.

Peter brings up a glass to his face, taking a small sip. She furrows her brows in confusion. She’s definitely seem him take much bigger sips of other stuff. “Didn’t you say it was good?”

“You know that I’m human, right? I can’t drink a lot of Asgardian alcohol at once, it’s too strong for me.”

Oh. She hasn’t even thought of that when she should have.

“Do you want to drink something else?” She’s pretty sure she’s seen a couple more bottles of beer in the fridge.

“No, I’m good,” he reassures her. “I just need to go slow.”

“You sure?”

“Absolutely.”

***

She doesn't necessarily love drinking—but she also doesn't hate it.

With Peter in front of her, them sitting on the floor between their bed bunks and Christmas music playing in the background, she almost can tolerate the taste of alcohol. Especially when she realizes she cannot feel the effects of it.

Frankly, she hasn't drunk much, but the fact that she hasn't lost control makes her loosen up. A lot.

Almost relieved, she takes another shot.

***

Peter's telling her about his time with the Ravagers, she knows that much, but she's having a hard time focusing on the story. She tries to look him straight in the eyes, but her gaze dips down every few seconds.

She's acutely aware of how close he's sitting—so close that his thigh almost touches her knee. The heat coming from his body makes her head spins.

He's close and yet not close enough. Her inhale is shaky.

***

She's still mesmerized by how close they sit. Her heart thumps in her chest, and she takes another shot just to occupy her hands with something.

***

She caves in. Shifting a little, she nudges the side of his thigh with her knee.

Something really warm creeps up in her stomach, spreading higher and higher until it sits right in her chest. Her fingers practically itch with the need to do something stupid, and she busies herself with pouring another shot.

***

When she tries to grab the bottle the next time, she misses. Frowning, she looks at her hand, confused, and tries again.

This time, her fingers wrap around the glass without a problem.

***

Peter's smile is so wide. So bright. For a moment, she cannot focus on anything else.

The words he's saying fade away. She simply watches his lips move.

***

He shifts. That makes his thigh press tighter against her, and she sucks in a breath.

She can’t look away from where they’re touching for a long time.

***

Something nags at her. She isn’t sure what’s the reason, or why.

***

It takes her a while to realize her field of vision isn’t as wide anymore.

It takes her even longer to notice that she isn’t necessarily too bothered by that.

Should she be?

But then again—why?

***

“Come here,” Peter says, holding up his holo. “Let me show you that picture.”

She tilts her head to the side, trying to process the words. It takes her repeating them inside her head a few times before she finally moves towards him.

She means to put her hand on the floor—in that tiny space between their bodies—while she’s pushing onto her knees, but she accidentally places it on his thigh instead. Not having expected that, she falters a little, her elbow bending, and she falls forward.

The world sways. Then it doesn’t.

“Hey. You okay?”

There’s something warm. She looks down, finding fingers wrapped around her forearm.

Peter’s fingers.

Her gaze drops even lower, to where she’s touching him. *Gripping* him.

She yanks her arm away—or tries to. The speed at which it moves isn’t what she intended it to be. It’s much slower. Yet, it’s enough to send her flying to the left.

She feels an arm on her waist now.

Warm. She makes a soft sound.

Then looks up, blinking at Peter.

It takes her a few seconds to realize how close he is.

Closer than ever before. That makes her inhale.

Her vision swims, though. To ground herself, she locks her gaze on the green of his eyes.

“Gamora?”

She cannot see anything but him. Close. So close.

“Mhm?”

“Are you okay?”

“No.”

She thinks his face lengthens. “What’s wrong?”

She frowns. He’s close, his lips are *right here*, and she cannot see anything else. She wouldn’t call that wrong.

She’s just not okay. He’s close.

Or maybe she is. He’s close.

She shakes her head. “I’m good.” That she is.

Forcing herself to focus on anything but his mouth, she thinks about the reason she’s gotten this close. “Oh. Your holo. You wanted to show me something.”

Does her voice sound weird? The sounds aren’t as clear? Or are they?

Peter releases his hold on her. She immediately frowns. And sways a little.

Her body feels heavy. She wants to sit down.

Looking back to where she was a few moments ago, she finds the space between where she is now and the side of her bunk too big.

She plops down next to Peter.

Now, her left shoulder presses firmly against his.

She shivers.

He draws his knees closer to his body and places the holo on them, angling it towards her.

Before she props her head on her hand she fails a couple times. When she finally succeeds, she attempts to focus on the screen but fails.

The new position she has found herself in brings her too close to the side of his head. His scent invades her nostrils, spinning her head, and she inhales deeply, making everything worse.

Or maybe better.

Definitely better.

But not for long.

“I will miss this once I’m gone.” She doesn’t mean to blurt the words out, but they spew from her mouth.

A long moment passes before Peter says anything. He clears his throat. “Do you have to go?”

She doesn’t understand the question. Her slow, sluggish thoughts make it hard to decipher the meaning. She chews on her cheek on the inside. “I guess.”

“You guess?”

“I mean… what else is there to do?”

“Stay.”

Her lips part in surprise. She thinks she goes utterly still—except for her heart.

Stay.

Never before has a single word mattered this much.

Her voice shakes a little. “Stay?”

“Stay.”

Stay.

She swallows. Lets out a shake exhale. And asks, “Why?”

“Because I want you to.” His words have her heart pounding. “But more than that, because I hope you want it too.”

Oh.

Her exhale is shaky.

His gaze, locked on hers, draws everything out of her. It gives her everything too.

“Do you?”

The truth has waited to be revealed for a long time—so it slips from her lips easily. “I do.”

She doesn’t hear Peter’s exhale, but she feels it on her face.

Close. He’s so close.

She fears what she doesn’t know—and yet, she craves it all the same.

Her eyes fall to his lips.

Pink. Soft. *Right here.*

She has always stolen glances before. Right now, she doesn't steal anything. She indulges.

She doesn't think she could ever look away.

"Mora…"

She doesn't hear the name—she *sees* the lips move.

And then they get closer.

She doesn't realize it's her who's moving at first.

She doesn't care.

Her eyes dart up. She meets the green. She soaks the green in.

Nothing else exists.

She drops her arm down, needing support. Or maybe she simply needs to touch Peter. Her palms lands on his wrist, and she watches his lips part.

"Mora…"

A warning? A plea? Something in between? In her state, she doesn't know. The only thing she knows is that she wants this. A lot.

Too much not to do it.

She feels his shuddered exhale on her lips. She shivers.

Then she shivers again when he takes her by her forearm.

She licks her lips when his mouth opens a little.

And then her world crumbles down around her when he says "No."

No.

She doesn't understand the word at first. But when she does, she recoils.

No.

No. No. No. Such a simple word—and yet, it brings so much confusion.

No?

No.

Hurt seizes her.

What a fool.

She tries to yank her arm away.

“Wait, Gamora— No.”

No.

“Gamora— Wait, look at me.” His fingers wrap tighter around her arm.

She places a hand against his chest, but the contact doesn’t bring comfort anymore. Embarrassment fuels her anger, and she pushes hard, trying to send him flying backwards. “Let me go.”

“No—”

“Let me go!”

She pushes again, without looking at him.

She needs to get away. And then she needs to *get away*.

She almost *stayed*.

The irony burns her eyes. Except it’s not irony, it’s tears.

She growls, she thinks. “Hands off of me, Quill.”

He doesn’t listen to her. If anything, he catches both of her wrists in his other hand. “Hey, hey — just look at me. Please.”

She doesn’t look at him. She tries to break free, but her body doesn’t listen to her. Her muscles feel weak, heavy, and she groans in frustration.

“Let me go!”

He does. A moment later his hands are gone, and she tries to spring to her feet, but she’s slow, the world is blurry, and he stops her before she can get up.

He stops her with his *hands*. On her face.

He cups her face, brushing away her tears, and for a long second, she’s paralyzed. Stunned, utterly mortified and flustered—but then she tries to break free even harder.

She also makes a whimper—and she hates herself for it.

“Gamora, I—” He stops himself and then releases a shaky laugh. Or maybe a scoff. “Do you think I *don’t* want to kiss you?”

She doesn't reply to him. She only bites down on her lower lip to stop another whimper from coming out. Whimper—or a sob.

"God, Gamora, you— you're *all* I think about. *Of course* I want you, but… not when you're drunk. Not when you don't know what you're doing."

She doesn't know what she's doing now, but she knew what she was doing then. She knew—and that makes everything worse. So much worse.

She makes a sound.

Broken.

Just like her.

Peter's mouth twists. Mouth she tried to *kiss. What a goddamn fool.*

His fingers tighten around her face. "I *will* kiss you for the rest of my life if I ever have a chance to do that." She thinks her stomach flips. There's something wrong with it. "But not when you might regret this. I don't want to be a drunk impulse. I want more than that. For you, for me, for us."

For us.

Thick, warm, painful tension spreads through her entire body.

She fights the shivers. She channels her anger. She fails—as she's drowning in pain. It makes her jab a finger in his chest, "It wasn't an impulse, you fool!"

He blinks at her.

She holds his gaze, angry and hurt.

"You…" He trails off. Then shakes his head a little, closing his eyes, his chest collapsing rapidly. "I'm only human," he mutters under his breath.

When he reopens his eyes, he inhales deeply. And then—

Then his forehead touches hers.

And she feels his warm breath on her skin.

All of a sudden, it's hard to breathe.

A second later, his lips come into contact with her cheek.

She makes a startled noise. Jolts a little.

He leans away, still holding her gaze. When he speaks, it's close to her face—*so* close, *too* close. "I want you."

Simple. Honest. She is having a hard time breathing.

He leans in again, leaving another kiss on her cheek, closer to her lips.

She whimpers.

His forehead rests against her. His whisper is hot, "I want you, but you love control, and it makes you feel safe. When I said I was in your corner, I meant it. Even if looking out for you means protecting you from you."

"I…" But she doesn't have anything to say.

She cannot even think.

"Alcohol messes up with your instincts. I don't want you to wake up tomorrow and have regrets. But if you still feel the same way, I will be right here."

She swallows her fear—and then it feels like lead in her stomach. "What if I'm too scared?" *What if I'm too broken to be brave?*

"Then it only proves that nothing should happen tonight."

Her chest feels hollow. Warm too. She's confused. She's hopeful. She's frustrated with him—and she's grateful. She's all over the place, and she's *tired*. Of everything. Fears. Reservations.

But who she is without those?

Happy. She longs for the voice inside her head be true.

"I… I don't know what to do," she admits on an exhale.

"What do you *want* to do?" He murmurs into her skin.

To let go. Just for a moment.

She almost kissed him—surely she can let go.

Something inside her snaps—and she lets her body sag against Peter's. She angles her head a little, and the side of her nose brushes his jawline. She brings up her hands and wraps them around Peter's wrists.

"To stay," she whispers.

He goes utterly still—except for a rumble in his chest. She hears it, she feels it, and then she suddenly realizes that maybe bravery isn't the absence of fear. Maybe it's about making a choice despite the knots in her chest.

"Then stay," he practically rasps.

"Okay."

Okay. One word—but oh so powerful.

Peter tries to lean back, but she protests, tightening her hold on his wrists. “No. Can— can we just stay like this? For a little bit?”

She doesn’t know if she’s feeling vulnerable because of the alcohol—or because of the conversation. She isn’t sure if she’s drunk—or simply cracked open, her feelings laid out in front for everyone to see.

Her world ends and begins with the person in front of her—but is it her heart, or is it her tunnel vision?

She doesn’t know much. But she knows she doesn’t want to move.

“Please,” she adds.

“Of course.”

He shifts a little, leaning against the metal side of his bunk bed, pulling her together with him. She follows willingly.

With her head under his chin, on his shoulder, she drags her knees up to her chest, and closes her eyes.

Losing herself in the moment is easy.

Pulling herself out of it is hard.

She doesn’t think she moves until Peter whispers, “You have to go to your bed now. I… I can’t restrain myself much longer. Please.”

She pulls away. Blinks at him, half asleep, half lost in the warmth of his body. “Restrain yourself?”

“I’ve had a lot to drink,” he says simply. “And I want to throw all reservations out the window. I won’t— you deserve better. But… I need you to move.”

Oh.

Her cheeks burn a little.

She slides away from him, pushing back until she sits opposite him. Just like when they started—except everything has changed. Hasn’t it?

“What happens next?”

“Whatever you want.”

Whatever you want.

chapter 6

She alternates between looking at Peter and looking at the bottle of liquor they consumed.

He's deep asleep. The bottle is almost empty. She's awake. Very much so.

Whatever you want.

She watches his chest rise. She watches it fall. She listens to his soft breathing, losing herself in the moment, and when the itching under her skin gets unbearable, she picks up her holo.

Christmas on Terra.

She scrolls for a really long time. She doesn't really read anything, having learned everything she needed to know from Peter, but she looks intently at all the pictures.

The decorations are almost mesmerizing. She's never seen so many coloured lights at the same time.

The itching under her skin gets stronger. She also feels tired. The pillow looks almost too appealing, and for a brief nano-second, she considers lying down. She then looks at Peter again—and a moment later she gets out of bed.

Padding across the hallway, she walks towards the med bay. Her vision has improved, just like her sense of coordination and clarity. The haze has gone away, too, but she doesn't want to risk anything.

She hooks herself up to a machine. Sets up an IV too.

Leaning back against the seat, she closes her eyes and waits for her body to metabolize every last drop of alcohol in her system. After a short while, something *clicks*—and she feels like she's back to normal.

The soft sounds in the cockpit finally reach her ears. The tunnel vision disappeares completely. When she purposefully lets go of a vial, her arm shoots down and catches the bottle before it can smash into tiny pieces.

Hearing. Vision. Reflexes. All back.

The senses return next. Sensibility. Rationality. *Fear.*

She mentally stomps down on it.

Y*ou love control, and it makes you feel safe.* She does. It is.

I don't want you to wake up tomorrow and have regrets. She does—but not about him.

Then stay.

She will.

***

She flies the Milano to Xandar. It's almost weird, returning back. Knowing she's about to climb aboard her ship—ship that doesn't feel like hers anymore.

Maybe the person she used to be. Lonely. Isolated. Dark.

She doesn't want to be in solitude anymore. She wants a mess in the kitchen. Pristine cleanliness is nothing but a stark proof of lack of life—and she's not happy with it anymore.

Alone, she suffer. Together with Peter, she lives.

And maybe he doesn't need any words. Maybe he doesn't need proof. Maybe he doesn't need her to do anything.

But *she* does. More than anything. One thing she needs to do for herself.

Just be brave enough to *show*. Prove to herself she can do *one* thing—and then a million more.

So she flies to Xandar, and when she docks the Milano, Peter still asleep, she sends him a quick message.

Please don't leave Xandar. Wait for me. I have to do something, but I will be back soon.

She then leaves the Milano behind.

***

She stares at the ration bar in her hand, her stomach churning a little. She then looks up, peeking into the cupboard, and finds nothing but more bars. No fruits, no chips, no cured meat. Just bland, tasteless bars.

Her mouth twists angrily, and she smashes the ration bar between her fingers. The packaging bursts open and the sticky texture instantly covers her hand. She grunts in frustration.

Throwing what's left of the bar away, she wipes her hand. When she looks at her skin, she sees nothing. And yet, she sees everything.

Thanos enforced ration bars, and she blindly followed the rules—even after he was long gone. A huge pile of ration bars in the cupboard is proof—proof that makes rage build in her stomach.

The thought of eating something tasteless, something just to *sustain life*, enrages her.

When she reaches inside the cupboard, she removes more than just the bars.

When she throws them away, she gets rid of more than just food.

She doesn't realize she's breathing heavily until she looks down. Something hot burns her from the inside, and an empty cupboard isn't enough. She needs more. She needs to get rid of *everything*.

But there's nothing here. Her ship is empty, lifeless. Nothing but the necessities—and her chest practically splits open with how much she's already missing chaos and mess.

She reaches for a tumbler—just one lone tumbler she owns—and throws it against the wall. A loud clang isn't satisfying. Nothing is.

She slams the cupboard door shut and strides across the room.

Cockpit. Now.

She cannot wait to get off the ship.

She wants to burn it to the ground.

***

Being on Terra without Peter is almost wrong. Her heart clenches, consumed by longing she feels with every cell of her body.

She doesn't explore the planet, she barely sees anything, and yet, she has so many questions. All too often she catches herself opening her mouth—all in that split second before the realization hits in.

Peter isn't here. He's million light years away.

But she's used to his presence. She doesn't want to change that.

***

She doesn't feel great about stealing, but she has no means of buying. She has nothing to offer of equal value either—which is the reason she is stealing in the first place.

She can't give Peter anything *but* this.

So she swallows her mild discomfort and reminds herself of something that makes her *very* uncomfortable: if she stops now, it's Peter who won't have anything.

She'd rather hurt a stranger.

***

She's on her way back when a message pops up on her holopad. From *Dey*.

Mouth suddenly dry, she stares at the screen for a long moment. Her fingers hover over the holopad, and she swallows thickly, on the fence. Open—and get angry. Open—and get some good news.

She pushes her hair out of her face. Takes a deep breath. And then swipes up, opening up the chair.

A moment. Two. Three. And then she sits bolt up, eyes wide.

Yondu's location. He was spotted there a few hours ago. I hope this helps.

No way. This isn't real—except that it is, and her face breaks into a smile, a short laugh falling from her lips.

She instantly draws up to her full height and runs upstairs, taking the ship off autopilot. Her hands shake a little when she enters the new coordinates—*Yondu's* coordinates. Once the route is calculated, displayed in the air in front of her, she almost chokes, surprised.

Excitements comes first. Frustration follows quickly.

She doesn't have to make a huge detour—the planet where Yondu's at is close to Xandar. It's just four jumps away.

But it *is* four jumps away—practically *nothing*.

All this time… She grunts. *What a selfish, self-centred asshole.*

She's not impressed with him. At all.

Shaking her head, she heaves a sigh. Then clicks on *Confirm* and quickly sits down, buckling up.

Sitting still is the last thing she wants to do, fuelled now by anger and hurt on Peter's behalf, but she lets it cultivate and grow inside her, willing to unleash it on the one person who deserves to be yelled at.

***

She doesn't knock. He doesn't deserve it. She simply yanks the doorknob out, thankful for shady planets and outdated design, and kicks the door with her foot. A second later, it meets the wall on the other side of the room.

Yondu doesn't even stir.

She steps inside the room, opening her mouth to yell when the stench of alcohol, sweat and gods know what else makes her gag. Coughing instinctively, she curses the passed out man in front of her, and strides across the room.

No movement. Still.

She kicks him in the side with her boot.

He doesn't react.

She kicks again.

This time he moves, even if it's not the movement she desires. His eyes are still closed, breathing deep and even; he simply turns to the side, now face to the ceiling, and pushes his duvet down.

Exposing his naked chest.

"Ugh." She makes a face, unable to stop herself.

Looking around, she spots another door. Washroom, maybe? When she checks it out, her suspicions are confirmed.

Walking over to a desk, she grabs a pint that smells like cheap, sour beer. *Disgusting*. Wrinkling her nose, she walks into the bathroom and fills the pint with cold water.

And then dumps it over Yondu's head.

He lets out a yelp, instantly sitting, eyes wild. Before she can react, he whistles, and a second later, an arrow is right in front of her face, mere inches away from her nose.

He didn't. She lets out a grunt, instantly pissed. "Get this thing away from me before I get out my sword."

"You will be dead before you do that."

He didn't.

Her eyes narrow at him. And then his eyes widen—once the Godslayer is in his face and her fingers are around his arrow. All in a split second, before either of them even blinked.

"H-how did you—" he sputters. "How the hell did you do that?"

Before he can whistle again, she presses the blade to his mouth, silencing him. "Put your arrow away. I'm not here to hurt you or kill you." She wishes she could do the former, but she's trying to make Peter happy, *not* upset him.

Yondu only hums against the blade.

"If you whistle, you'll regret it."

She removes the Godslayer—but barely. Just enough to talk.

No whistle comes.

"Smart," she says. "Now, get ready. We're leaving."

"I ain't going anywhere."

She blinks at him. Slowly. Is he truly that stupid? "You have no choice. I'm not asking."

“You—”

She presses the blade back to his lips. The sword is angled this time, though, picking at the skin above below his nose. She takes a step closer to him, done wasting her time.

“You are ungrateful, self-centred, and immature, and I would spend the rest of my life without ever trying to find you. But someone I care about very much loves you and wants to see you, which means I’m going to make it happen. We’re leaving *now*.”

Confusion clouds Yondu’s eyes. A second later, there’s understanding. He hums something, but the sound is muffled, so she removes the blade.

“You talkin’ about… Quill?” He sounds almost unsure.

“Good to know you remember who that is.” Her eyes shift to a holopad on the floor, half hidden under the bed. “It’s also good to know that you *do* have technology to respond to messages.”

“I ain’t—”

“I’m not interested,” she cuts him off. “Don’t talk. Just get ready.”

He lifts up his chin defiantly. She pulls her arm away, instead angling the Godslayer toward the arrow. “Do you want to bet my sword could easily cut through Yaka before you even blink?”

Yondu’s smart enough not to say anything, even if the way his eyes darken, mouth twisting, is clearer than any words could ever be.

She wants to make something clear too. “I will break your arrow and leave you defenceless in a second. Hell, I’ll even cut out your prothesis.” She levels him with her gaze. “After I do that, I’ll let the members of your old clan know where to find you, and I’ll personally guard you until they arrive. You don’t have a choice, Yondu. It’s either that—or coming with me.” Something burns her throat. Something like anger and disbelief and irritation. “You want to break Peter’s heart, you do that in person. Stop hiding like a coward.”

He holds her gaze for a few long moments. Then he scoffs, shaking his head. “Bossy, huh?” He cocks his head to the side. “But what do you expect from daughter of Thanos?”

He’s trying to rattle her—but she stares at him blankly. “So you’ve heard about me then. Congratulations.”

You know what I’m capable of is left unsaid. Yondu must have at least some common sense because he weighs his options.

She knows what he wants to do—she watches him watch the arrow.

A promise. A warning. Everything in between. She lowers her sword, the edge of it coming in contact with Yaka.

She can play the game too. She's not here to come to Peter with nothing.

Eventually, Yondu lets out a low, unhappy growl. "Damn Terran. Shoulda eaten him when I had a chance." It's only because she hears a certain level of warmth in Yondu's voice that she doesn't do anything.

"Get ready," she repeats.

Yondu gives her a sugary-sweet smile. "As you wish."

He pushes the duvet aside and gets up to his feet. *Naked.*

She makes a startled noise, instantly turning around. "You bastard," she growls lowly.

He laughs, cold and not amused. "I'm out of bed. Ain't this what you wanted?"

She feels her face contort. Breathing in and out, she says nothing.

***

He tests her patience in many ways. She doesn't react to any single one of them, but on the inside, she's fuming. The only reason she doesn't snap is by entertaining the idea of someone getting him before next Christmas.

She refuses to go through the same experience again.

It takes her a while to realize what her thoughts imply. When she does, she freezes, startled. She plays with the truth in her mind, trying to admit the intention without actually voicing it, but she can't.

Because she *is* thinking of staying.

For that long. And maybe… maybe even longer than that.

***

Hey Peter. Can you please meet me at the same bar we went to after the mission?

His reply is almost instant. *You want to go there?*

She will never step inside if she can help it, but she doesn't know any other bars. She still has a mission to accomplish—even if Yondu is the main present now.

Not wishing to lie, she ignores Peter's question. **Can you meet me there in about an hour? I'm on my way back to Xandar.**

*Where **did** you go?*

He's asked that a few times since she left. She's avoided the question every single time. **I will tell you later**.

***

Dey, Yondu is coming with me to Xandar. Just giving you a head ups.

You really like to make my job more difficult.

If he does something terrible, arrest him. But please make sure no one arrests him for his past crimes.

I hope it's worth it.

***

"You are *not* to run away," she says. Orders, really. "If you do, I will find you."

Yondu only rolls his eyes.

"I'm serious, Yondu." She folds her arms on her chest. "You are to wait at this bar until Peter arrives. You have to keep him occupied for couple of hours. What you do after doesn't concern me."

He waves her off. "I'm more interested in what you're gonna be doing in the meantime."

"That's none of your business."

He snorts. "I've seen your ship." His lips twist in a sneer. A condescending one. "Sentimental nonsense, those decorations. You're gonna decorate Quill's ship, aren't you?"

She would be self-conscious if she wasn't annoyed. Her first time giving a present—and Yondu *is* telling her she's doing something foolish. She thinks if that was anyone else, she would probably let the fear inside her win. She would merge the voice of the person with the voice inside her own head. She *would* believe she's making a mistake.

Luckily for her, it's Yondu. His opinion matters less than anyone else's ever has.

His regard for Peter's feelings is approximately non-existent. He doesn't get an opinion.

She doesn't dignify his remark with a response. She only points to the bar. "Go inside. Now."

"You're forgetting something, sweetheart."

She ignores the nickname—she already learned he enjoys it when she shows her frustration. "What's that?"

"I ain't paying my own money for that. Transfer me some units."

Peter spent weeks searching for him—and he can't even pay ten units for a cheep beer. *What an astonishing parental figure.* She takes a deep breath. "I'll never understand why Peter loves you so much."

Yondu shrugs. “I’ll never understand what he found in you. You ain’t hearing me complain ‘bout it.”

“You’ve literally been complaining for the past two hours.”

He shrugs again, almost in a *What can you do* way.

She pulls her holo out. “What’s your code?”

***

When she’s finally back on the Milano, she feels like crying. Inhaling the air, seeing the inside of the ship, she’s overwhelmed by one single word in her head.

Home.

She hasn’t had one in so long, she doesn’t even understand the feeling—or the concept—but she’s hit with the sudden revelation: this *is* home. She doesn’t want to be anywhere else.

For a moment, she regrets sending Peter away. She wants nothing more than to be here with him, Yondu be damned, but unfortunately, she’s the only one who can’t stand him.

Peter needs him.

She wishes Yondu needed him back. She wishes Yondu *showed* his love. Peter’s love is obvious, almost palpable. He deserves the same kind of affection back.

She slowly walks around the ship, soaking everything in. It’s almost surprising—but also so obvious—that there’s nothing to get accustomed to. Two days apart haven’t changed anything. She already knows every corner.

She already *loves* every corner.

Home. Home. Home.

Her heart flutters in her chest.

***

Holding the lights with one hand, she tries to tear tape with her teeth, wrinkling her nose at the bitter taste of the glue on her tongue.

The pictures made it look easy and effortless.

She’s struggling.

She’s not even supposed to be feeling tension in her shoulders—but she *is*. Either the Milano is much bigger than she ever realized, or she stole too many Christmas lights, but there is a lot to hang up.

The strings of lights like to complicate everything by getting tangled up.

When she untangles one part of the string, lifting it up in the air, another part instantly forms a knot.

She doesn't understand how that happens.

Sighing, she hops off the chair, stretching her neck a little.

Just two more walls to go.

***

As soon as she puts a star on top of the Christmas tree, she hears a voice right outside the Milano. *Peter's* voice. Her heart skips a bit in anticipation, and she rocks on her heels, clasping her hands behind her back.

Licking her lips, she takes a deep, calming breath.

A second voice joins Peter's. *Yondu's.*

Everything inside her churns. She didn't expect audience.

Her eyes dart around in panic. *Everything* is decorated. Everything is bright, everything is festive, and suddenly she cares very much about what Yondu has—had—to say. The sneer he gave her burns her eyelids, and she closes her eyes, nauseous.

What was she thinking?

Stupid, stupid, stupid.

When the door starts opening, she makes a soft noise in the back of her throat. Retreat. *Now*. But apprehension slows her down, and before she can hide somewhere down the hall, Peter's eyes find hers.

His wide grin cracks his face in two—or at least starts cracking. His mouth opens, possibly to greet her, when he notices the lights—and the tree, and the tall figurines of gods know who—and then his eyes widen, lips forming an O rather than a smile.

The look in his eyes has her unsure how he feels about this.

She bites her tongue to stop an embarrassing sound from coming out.

"'Course you did that," Yondu mutters behind Peter. "You better have some beer here, Quill."

Peter doesn't say anything. Gamora doesn't either. A few seconds later Yondu sighs and moves past both of them, possibly in the direction of the kitchen.

Gamora isn't sure. She cannot look away from Peter.

"I, uh… What is this?"

She's asking herself the same. What. And *why?* This was such a bad idea.

She wants the ground to open up under her feet.

"I…" She trails off.

Peter's eyes dart between her and the tree. She follows his gaze and tries to see everything through his eyes.

The tree is crooked and patchy. There's couple spot where she didn't put enough decorations, and now the green branches look naked. The lights blink too aggressively. She should have chosen another setting.

No blinking would have been nice.

No lights would have been even better.

Her throat closes up.

Peter slowly walks over to the tree, his hand hovering over the decorations, and she can't see his face anymore. She hears his racing heart though. Good racing? Bad racing?

She doesn't know.

He turns to her slowly—and a confused, delighted, bright smile takes his entire face. A *smile*. It finds home in her heart, and something in her relaxes.

"Gamora," he practically whispers, "what is this?"

A smile reminds her how to talk. "I wanted to give you something." Her voice is chocked, but she is already obvious and transparent. She might as well say the truth—even if it's not *the* truth. "I… I was worried we wouldn't find Yondu in time, so I thought I'd give you at least something. I didn't want you to not celebrate."

His lips part a little. Something soft settles in his eyes. Soft, tender, and so familiar she feels a wave of heartache sweep over her, knocking all wind out of her.

He slowly walks over.

When he stops in front of her, he's close. *So* close. Too close—he's practically towering over her, and she doesn't feel trapped. She only feels at home.

"Gamora…" Her name is nothing but a breathless whisper.

She feels the quiet voice awake something in the pit of her stomach. Fire and desire—and the room, and everything in it, suddenly disappears.

His green eyes hold hers. The earnestness in his gaze leaves her breathless.

“At least something,” he murmurs, repeating her words, his tone is hushed and almost amused. “You already gave me everything when you agreed to stay.”

Her heart clenches so violently that she feels like she’s been stabbed. She wants to come up with something to say but her mind is blank. She fights the weird, hot haze. “You said that not celebrating Christmas would be like forgetting about your mom, and I didn’t want that.”

His hands cup her face, and she leans into his palm.

“I wouldn’t have not celebrated,” he says quietly. “I would have been with you. Christmas is about being with someone you love. I was. I am.”

I am.

She swallows thickly. And then again and again, fighting the urge to cry.

He rests his forehead against hers, his breath warm on her cheekbone. The proximity and the heat of his skin spins her head, and she takes a deep breath, unable to stop herself.

“It means the absolute world to me what you did. With decorations. With Yondu. This is the best thing anyone has *ever* done for me, Gamora, and I…” He trails off, his voice thick with gratitude. Her hands itch with the need to touch him, and she lifts up her arms, slowly wrapping her fingers around his forearms.

He leaves a soft kiss on her cheek.

She’s not even embarrassed about a soft exhale that falls from her lips.

She’s too busy trying to breathe. And replaying the kiss. And the words.

Everything.

“I am so grateful, but— No, wait, there’s no but— I just… I don’t want you to think you had to do it. Having you here was—and *is*—enough. It’s everything.”

She sucks in a shaky, uneven breath. Leans away just a little, wanting to look at him, and the words come pouring out of her. “No one has ever made me feel safe, Peter. No one but you. And— not just safe. It’s— well, everything else too. But I’m not good with words, so I thought I’d show you.”

Have I shown you? The question burns her tongue.

The answer blazes in his eyes. *You have.*

Relief—and happiness, and giddiness, and apprehension—spill in her chest. She *has* shown —and she’s *alright*. The world hasn’t ended. If anything, it’s brighter now—with the way Peter’s eyes shine with everything she’s craving and feeling back.

She *is* safe. The realization is freeing. So freeing.

“Thank you,” he whispers, his lips close to hers.

She wants them closer. A shiver of anticipation races down her neck.

Closing her eyes, she whispers into his skin, “Can I have that kiss you promised me?”

She doesn’t see his smile, but she feels the corners of his lips lift up. “I believe I promised you a million, actually.”

She doesn’t know where she finds the boldness—but she does. “Go on, then.”

She isn’t sure who moves first. She doesn’t know if there was even any space to move—maybe they just needed to shift a little. But his lips touch hers, and she is *home.*

Suddenly, Peter’s everywhere, and she doesn’t want anything else.

The kiss is searing, leaving her breathless, and she thinks she makes a soft noise. Or maybe Peter does.

She doesn’t know. She doesn’t care.

She only wants more.

Raising on her tiptoes, she slides her hands higher, until her fingers curl around his hair. Peter makes a soft moan, one she feels deep in her belly, and his hand drops her her waist.

His palm presses against her back. She goes in willingly, pressing her chest, her stomach, against him.

The softness becomes teasing. The teasing is playful—and then tender. It’s lingering. Long-lasting.

When his tongue touches hers, she whimpers.

His fingers curl around her jaw.

Hers instinctively curl around his waves.

When he breaks away, her knees almost buckle at the sight of him. The intoxicating desire makes her weak. The dark, intense hunger fuels her own. But it’s that other thing, that soft, tender, beautiful affection, that has her gasping.

She blurts out, “Earlier, when I was flying Yondu to Xandar, I kept thinking how terrible he is and how much I don’t want to do this next year.” She bites her lip. “*Next year*, Peter. I was thinking about it. I still am.” She gives him a small smile. “I want this.”

His lips press another kiss to her mouth.

She responds just as eagerly. Her hands slide down, brushing his shoulders—

“Well, ain’t a fan of you either, sweetheart.”

She freezes. A second later, she groans.

Peter already spent some time with him. Would it be terrible of her to message Dey and ask him to arrest Yondu, after all? The idea is tempting.

Peter pulls away from her, his eyes narrowed. “Get the hell out of here.”

Yondu doesn’t listen, of course. If anything, he laughs darkly, not bothered at all, and walks over. “Ain’t leaving, Quill. Your lady dragged me here against my will, so I’m going to stay for a bit.”

Peter’s face falls. “Please don’t.”

She looks at Yondu over her shoulder. “You’re free to leave.”

“And miss a chance to annoy you?” He cocks his eyebrow. “Not doing that. Maybe that will teach you something.”

She grunts. He just smirks.

“I can get you arrested,” she tells him.

He only snorts. “You wouldn’t risk upsetting Quill.”

“I will personally call Dey,” Peter says.

Yondu rolls his eyes. “Get over it, Quill. I’m staying for dinner.” He slaps Peter on the shoulder. “Now, let’s go. I’m starving. The faster we eat, the faster I leave you two alone.”

Peter lets out a long sigh, giving Gamora a sheepish, apologetic smile. “I see why you weren’t a fan of him.”

“Insulting me won’t make me leave.”

Gamora swallows back a groan. “You’re insufferable.”

“Right back at ya,” Yondu winks at her.

She presses her lips together.

“Let’s go, sweetheart. You’re here to stay, we gotta chat then.”

She counts to ten. It doesn’t help. She follows them both into the kitchen, quietly fuming.

But as soon as Peter’s hand finds hers, her irritation melts.

His smile is worth it. It’s worth everything.

He leaves a quick kiss on her cheek, whispering, “Thank you. And I’m sorry,” and she doesn’t mind anything at all.

She’s too busy feeling happy and safe.

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